

‘Eheu, fugaces labuntur anni.’

From One Lens to Another

ALI MANAN



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This copy has been dedicated to

The public

12/8/2026

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This eBook is an artistic display of the author's personal recollection, within various settings, which reflects the author's own memories, interpretations, and emotions.

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*To Fidel, Asilli, and all those who associated
themselves with LGSJT.*

FOREWORD

By Rayyan Naveed Ghuman

When I first met Ali, I never imagined I'd one day be writing the foreword to the sensational story that is his time in JT. Yet here I am, trying to capture in a few paragraphs the essence of someone whose tenure in JT has been anything but the ordinary. I met Ali about two years ago in the latter half of year nine following the great reshuffling of 9D. I had heard about his activities in 9G but had never really known him personally. However, when one day he walked into the newly formed 9D and became part of our new class and greeted me, I knew, from that point, that this would be the start of a budding friendship forged with a shared love of all things history and politics.

We remained acquaintances from that point forward for a while and we didn't really get to know each other until summer. One fateful day I decided to invite Ali to my Minecraft server called Rise and Conquer, a world map server where people built up nations, alliances and went to war. He happily accepted my invitation and we went on to be allies in the server, together plotting against our enemies and going to war. His ferocity and enthusiasm in server politics amazed me and it was through RaC that I really got to know Ali. I look back upon that time fondly, remembering the many hand drawn maps we made together fantasizing the partitioning of our enemies and the many strategy discussions we had which ended up further deepening our bond.

From One Lens to Another isn't just a collection of memories or milestones, it's a reflection of the person I've had the privilege of calling my friend. I've known Ali long enough to witness the numerous setbacks and shortcomings that he has faced, alongside periods of great political turmoil and friendships

broken. However, despite all of this I believe that he has learnt to reflect and grow from these experiences and jump back into the game with unparalleled determination, qualities that are hard to find nowadays. Testament to this general sentiment was Ali's reaction to becoming Mathematics Representative. It wasn't what he initially had hoped for however he gracefully accepted this new position and continued in that capacity.

Another vivid memory is of Ali, one evening, messaging me describing how he had mended ties with one of his older enemies, learning to forgive and forget their prior hostilities, a pivotal point marking a positive shift in his character. Even now, sitting in Australia thousands of kilometres away, I try to keep in touch with Ali, not allowing geographical constraints to hinder my relationship with one of the brightest and insightful people I know.

Overall, even though there were some ups and downs, my time in JT alongside Ali is unforgettable and I will *forever* cherish the friendships formed and deepened during my time there.

What you're about to read is not filtered or sugar-coated. It's bold, honest, sometimes messy but always inspiring. It's the story of someone who turned obstacles into opportunities and never let life dictate him in any way.

So, *take your time* with these pages. Laugh when it's funny, reflect when it gets deep, and above all, appreciate the rawness of a journey that's far from over.

I know I do.

— **R.N.G.**

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I M U S T begin this section with reverence for the Almighty due to His *undeniable* support and limitless Grace in every stage of my life, both physical and spiritual, without which none of my achievements would have gained substance.

If Muhammad Asil and Rayyan Naveed Ghuman had not stepped into my chaotic life within the bounds of JT as beacons of solace, this book would likely have ended in less than a dozen pages. Adelaide was roughly five hours ahead of me, yet Rayyan never failed to make time for our daily conversations — ranging from British politics to the drama unfolding in school. I was never one for voice notes and hour-long calls, yet every call with Asil held a sense of everlasting comfort. They never disappointed me; despite getting their hands on mere fragments of this manuscript, their enthusiasm never wavered.

My deepest gratitude goes to Shayan Amjad and Aareez Moazzam, who helped deliver the first blow in many engagements. Their sincerity and devotion to me remains sacred. They never hesitated to bail me out, and I would always look forward to their valuable opinions.

To the people of Demons are(n't) Dead: I have no words to describe how much I adore you all. Alman Ali, you have proved that no topic is truly off-limits. Taha Zeeshan, you have been there since the dawn of time, a charioteer smoking in the moonlight. Zayan Muneer, your exploits and shenanigans will never fail to amuse me, be it Hatay or the pits of the future. You all stood with the others to get us up and running. *Thank you for everything!*

I am extremely grateful to the people of Rise and Conquer and their unwavering support, particularly Ayaan Hassan bin Irfan, Naveed ul-Hassan

Bukhari, Shahzaib Ahmad, Hasan Shozib, and Hassan Raza Shah. The memories I have made with these folks and Rayyan Naveed over the years are priceless vines of gold draped over my mind, eternal in their own being. I cherish you all and the joys of being a part of the community.

A special thanks goes to Haroon Abbas, Sabeeh Alvi, Ibrahim Kalim, Hassan Dar, Haad Haroon, Yahya Chaudhry, Syed Muhammad Imaad, Bilal Tariq, Rayyan Butt, Yassi Ayaan Romail, Rafey Haider Khan, Rayyan Fahmeed, Mustafa Mesam, Abdul Rafay, Chaudhry Ahmed Mubashar, Abdullah Kashif, Rayyan Iqbal Khan, Ebaad Rizwan, Mustafa Nisar Cheema, Ayaan Nasser Malik, Ahmad Haq, and Ahmed Jamal for their cooperation and support during those three daunting years.

Different batches of students in the school have yielded many pleasant individuals who have been a source of inspiration for me. Credit goes to Ahmad Hassan Sohail, Anns Nadeem, Mujtaba ‘Ustaadji’ Imran, Abdullah Ahmed, Bilal Haroon, Humza Ahmed Raheel, Sarim Zaheer, Abdullah Maqbool, Abdullah (without the surname), Areeb Nauman Mir, Hashim Khurram, Aayan Tariq, Zoraiz Ilyas and Wahaj Ali for enriching life in the ashes.

My decade-old friends — Rayyan Zafar and Hashim Chaudhry — are somehow still willing to associate with me after ten years, while appreciating the strength of our relations even when time hammers itself upon them, for which I will always remain thankful.

I must also thank members of both Student Councils (2024-26) for discharging the responsibilities vested in their Mandates with dignity and their collaborative observances while working with me in different areas.

Faculty members came and went, but I must acknowledge the nurturing of Sirs Hamid Rashid, Rehan Baig, Hamza Arif, Talha Gul Khan, Javed Kausar, Zahid Mehmood, Abdul Jalil, Haris Tauqeer, Abdul Rauf, Imran Khaliq, Khalil Akhtar, Misses Humaira Bhutto, Shehzadi Jamila, Shaloof Abbas, Anam Kamal, Sabah Mehmood, Madiha Saeed, Nida Shoukat Ja’afari, Umbreen Zahid, and the two administrations that solemnly vowed to nurture me to the fullest.

‘Why JT?’ Doctor Nighat Khan smiled from her seat, pouring her eyes into the chubby middle-schooler sitting next to her desk in a checkered shirt. ‘I want to choose JT because I have seen the progress it has supported through the years, and I want to give this institution a chance to morph me into someone better.’

‘Why JT?’ Miss Faiqa questioned, three years later, scanning a lankier bloke with a goatee in a dotted tie sitting at the rear end of the circle. ‘This institution has been instrumental in the change we all could see through the three years I spent here,’ he began. ‘It chose to trust me twice with its Mandates, and now comes my turn to trust it.’

To Cadbury Oreo and Mars: I owe you the sweetness of my life. To Oculus and Meta: I owe you my return to refined reality as I stepped in the worlds within your headsets. To Bhurban: your blue-brown mountains have preserved every bit of me, every memory, every stage, every marvellous thought. *Stay shining!*

Mum and Dad deserve endless thanks for their patience and support throughout the years. Thank you for the countless late-night drives and the morning pep-talks in the car, which have become a ritual now.

I must also mention Mohammad Ahmed for the conversations we had during the fateful month of April which conceived the idea of ‘*preserving the history of JT and our batch.*’ Thank you for your cooperation during the utter chaos which later manifested a gargantuan Project Muskan e Sehat as we wiped the slate for everyone.

And to *all* my adversaries, past and present, and any in the future who gave me, or would give me countless hours, days, weeks, months, and years of torture, I bear no grievance against you on this day. The pits will remain hotter, and marvels will continue to manifest themselves, for your schisms have inspired me to write countless pages of undiluted art the turn of a page away.

— **A.M.P**

PROLOGUE

'Eheu, fugaces labuntur anni.'

-Horace, *the Odes*

Indeed it was the stroke of the midnight hour, after sealing the Islamiyat notes for the night, which compelled me to log off from the world for a few seconds to relax after ruthlessly slamming my poor old laptop's DELETE key to do away with the gibberish I concocted in place of fruitful deadlines for preparation.

I can cast my mind back to the first time I read these words from the *Odes*, as it whispers, '*Alas, the fleeting years skip by.*' Timeless words they are, which inspired me to smile at the past preserved in my mind. It satisfied the factions of my wit, and became part of the identity I cherish. Studying metaphors in third grade, I never understood what was the true essence of the classic '*Life is a rollercoaster.*' I had no idea of how far or wild the ride could go, how pleasing it would be to touch the stars after sinking into the merciless earth, sinking into it again, rising, sinking, rising and continuing this cycle to its undefined extremity.

The witching hour of April 12th, 2025 had just begun, and my windows restrained the vast expanse of pure darkness from marching into my immaculate room. A blend of Mizrahi, and Nassi's delicate tunes waltzed through the air into my headphones, pulsing through the black wires and soothing the nerves as if I had some paracetamol, while I surfed through my Drive for a file backup to read. Mohammad Ahmed, once an admired classmate and the Imam e Haazir of Lish-Fips Land, and by extension, the 'Old Left', who was appointed as the Senior Prefect, surfaced at the perfect time for some talks.

My mind entered a light trance, with a slideshow of random moments during the year. *'O-Levels is like the stock exchange,'* I remembered informing my mother as she swerved the car towards the Shoukat Khanum road on a sunny September afternoon, with the sun staring into my eyes. *'On some days, it goes pretty well and then, BOOM, a crisis can start without warning.'* Dayyan laughed, while he reached for my phone to watch some Shorts. He definitely just stayed at the tip of the iceberg.

A series of documents engraved in 'Poetic Work: Classified' appear in the folder I was scrutinizing. Every single component of that file resonated with an era from my time in JT or a historical perspective, but they were not explicit. The titles or the terms used might be spoilers, I must say, but the power to transcend the boundaries of words, to give a self-standing exegesis, was nowhere.

So Ahmed spoke about deep things which the memory of a goldfish I possess can not retrieve while I am writing this prologue. My temples twitched and I thought once more, trying to conceal a somewhat daft yet marvellous idea, *'How about cooking a piece of art?'*

'It will be a great idea,' he declared, *'It would prove rather interesting if someone decides to really sit down and give substance to such a project.'* I revealed my intentions to Crystal (Naiel Umad) who had just finished his masterpiece, albeit I spat on the fairy-tail names he suggested, in disgust. I was elated beyond measure, I started writing, and for a week, the manuscript bore the name *'The Unnamed Book'*. Two sentences, and nothing else.

Then came the day when we were handed over the Statement of Entry for the two devilish Cambridge examinations of Pakistan Studies and Islamiyat. We gracefully stood at the edges of the hall, with the venerable Ma'am Faiqa addressing us for the first time. *'Look at me!'* she retorted, as I swerved back from another Council member towards the front of the stage where she was standing. I was lucky, for she was not infuriated by that.

'The outlook of JT has changed. We stand to be the midwife of a new era. May God help us go through the transition.' I harked back to Zayan Muneer's

words. I put two and two together, and thought that a change of lens from the Progressive to the Orthodox lens had occurred. We studied lenses in Physics, every geopolitical entity has always had its own set of lenses to look at the world, and so do I when it comes to my life at school. We were sitting in a mega-corporation where every single pawn had its own strategies, goals, epics, failures, inspirational figures, social circles, and ideologies.

As I sat down to write in the dead of the night once again, my mind clicked with a name, and that is what I sent to Ahmed. *'Pretty good name chap, this is going to be amazing,'* he thought.

July 2025 dawned in a new world altogether, revealing that the initial methodology for narrating the events post-Grade 10 CAIEs was entirely obsolete, by decree of the new social spectrum emerging in Grade XI. A delusional Ali lifted the pen off the page for two months, leaving the first manuscript of *'From One Lens to Another'* in utter disarray, with the initial part of post-May 2025 proceedings nothing more than a group of empty boats attempting to anchor themselves indiscriminately on the ocean floor with no docking area for miles around. One thing led to another, and finally, on a dark and gusty night, I took a random picture of my arm.

An arm's picture becomes an idea, the idea becomes a cover, and with that it becomes an eternal flame, a flame which made me write in its behest. A playlist later, I found myself saving the second out of three covers of this manuscript just before a minor earthquake, which set off a chain reaction in my mind in the middle of the night. *'It's as if all the fragments of the Black Stone have been returned by the Qarmatians to Mecca! You never really knew that the fragments came back a long, utterly long time ago, waiting to be looked at.'*

September and October 2025 complicated everything. Affairs went upside down, social structures fractured, friendships blew apart, the dominoes were falling down one by one. I was both happy and sad for not being at the centre of affairs or even the place where it all happened, but every hour, my phone buzzed and I was told everything that was happening. It reminded me of how the Bashar regime fell in the space of two weeks, except that this time, it occurred in

four days. There was none a scrap of earth for the fallen to seek asylum in, and the night of the 20th of September featured atrocity upon atrocity. Scandals were uncovered, people around the city got word about it, and a full-blown war erupted from March's friendliest front.

Yet, I continued. For me, life was '*a sine curve, bound to go down and bound to rise again unless you limit your life and grieve.*' Sitting in the sunshine of December's afternoons, I began putting two and two together with several people, framing the lenses after two and a half years' worth of conversations, attitudes, judgements, conflicts, jest, and actions.

Living things can never be stationary. That is what differentiates cells, organisms and systems from necropolises, lifeless carcasses and defunct theorems. The fragmentation of the human soul is what blesses the road of life with meaning and significance; that is why man pursues life, as he inevitably heads forward in search of those fragments. Mahmoud Darwish was quite experienced in this regard, and his words shall always bear the truth: '*You would not find the same person twice — even in the same person.*'

This publication is no different. This is an almanac where all the fragments of my Black Stone have been finally merged, as the loyal goldsmiths throughout my batch molded the fragments once again, uniting the different sets of lenses I had used to view the world. An exchange of lenses is an act scarcely done, yet a necessity for preserving the peace we fought so hard for in this world, so I invite you, *O Reader*. An exchange of different lenses is what will sustain this world, and let it start with *you*, and *me*.

The Room of Mirrors
November 7th, 2025

FROM ONE LENS TO ANOTHER

A MEMOIR

ALI MANAN

'He who seeks pearls must dive deep in the sea.'

-Imam Shafi'i

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The great Homer begins his Iliad as follows:

‘Sing in me, Muse, and through me tell the story

Of that man skilled in all ways of contending,

The wanderer... on the proud height of Troy’

August 21st, 2023 — May 27th, 2024

THE EXORDIUM

*'The people who cast the votes decide nothing.
The people who count the votes decide everything.'*

– Stalin

The hall had swollen beyond measure, with every ounce of the populace in JT rummaging for adequate space just to stand in. Huge, uneven patches of questions and the pitch-black embalmed the uncertainty in the air on that day, with contingents of students trussed up in navy blue or inky black coats emerging from either one of the two great double doors, as they creaked wide open to reveal a tranquil stage at the farthest end surrounded by students.

However, the nearest end of the hall was calm, and that is where I detected an uncrowded quarter, the 'Rub al-Khali' of the otherwise crowded area. The throngs standing in front of me with a decreasing gradient of heads poking out obstructed the view, due to which I decided not to give a tinker's toot to the proceedings, the sacraments and the solemn nature of what we had been assembled for.

'I genuinely have no idea what is going to happen with us,' Haad utters, lifting his lopsided spectacles and balancing them on his sharp, bony nose. He swerved to face the squatty, red-faced Shehroz, the usual gruff and grumpy, pot-bellied stripling, prompting me to break the ice with Imaad.

The hubbub of the assemblage ceases when Doctor Nighat steps up to the lectern, bearing a gigantic LGS logo with the bits of silver reflecting beams of silence piercing into the soul. *'Remember, it is not the badge which honours the man, but*

the man who does so,' she proclaimed, which managed to float on my absorbed mind. The preceding week buzzed with developments: a few more heedful steps on the journey I never asked for, a slump in Add. Maths for which the credit goes to my hasty migration skipping some key concepts, and the hectic timetable.

I peered at the six triangular ensigns drooping from the top of the equidistant red-bricked pillars supporting the monstrosity of a ceiling dotted with air vents, and lights. My aching eyes scrutinised the colours of the flags. A magnificent emblem was present, complemented by a disproportionate golden-yellow fringe and for the first time, I saw a mismatch in the colours associated with a house and the colour of the flag. Hawk House, for instance, was marked with an ornate maroon on my sports shirt but the flag bore no sight of that. Similarly, the brilliant blue of Eagle House was displaced to another house's flag, and my eyes finally rested upon the flag of Kestrel House, at the rear of the hall.

'THE CULTURE AND HERITAGE REPRESENTATIVE is, ZAYAN MUNEE!' Up stood Zayan, beaming as he swerved through the front of the line, the people making way for the first victor of the entire Council, the initiator of the entire Ceremony, as Shahmeer, Haroon, and Hassan wildly clapped in front of me.

The seconds felt like hours as Abdullah Kamran sauntered to the stage for receiving his Mandate for Alumni Representative, sparking the realization that I should have explored a bit more, and with this, they fired the first shot on me:

'HASHIM CHAUDHRY.'

'HASHIM CHAUDHRY.'

'HASHIM CHAUDHRY.'

My heart sank. It was plunged into the abyss once. Then again, and once more as the grand finale. They must have announced it once, but it echoed thrice in my mind. A coveted rank had fallen.

It was all over. The position I longed for was held hostage by a former friend, a teammate, and someone I loathed for not doing his part in our Lego pair. If it were Haadi or Ayaan Nasser, it would have been justified and purely legal, for they knew a lot about Robotics. They were adored by Sir Hamza, but *Hashim*? I knew not.

I took a deep breath, wheezing at the sight of what I aspired to hold in the hands of blatant Hashim. My face morphed into a red tomato, and luckily the inner-self kicked in to console me. '*There is going to be something better in store for you, Ali,*' it whispered, '*Chill.*' I lost my interest in the rest of the announcements for the Representatives.

Haadi and Ayaan Nasser stared at each other with bloodshot eyes gaping at the usurper of their wishes. Sir Hamza, as Haadi later narrated, shook his head in *disgust*. The shockwaves passed through the entirety of the Club, erupting dissatisfaction in the minds of a huge chunk of the devotees.

The troops in front of me descended into endless chatter. Nevertheless, the missiles continued striking its targets, summoning them to be a part of the Sacraments, bringing upheavals of occasional joy. The air reeked of disappointment, ecstasy, and a plethora of emotions from far and wide. A few more strikes and one part of the proceedings was done and dusted.

I took a deep breath and prepared myself for the worst. I closed my eyes to receive the final blow, and as I predicted:

'The Prefect of 9D is Mohammad Ahmed!'

I shoved myself aside and fell in despair. 'The Council is not for me,' I cried from deep within. Just ahead of me, Haad and Shehroz were getting pale in the face, waiting for their inevitable verdict. The procession became a nuisance for me, but after a minute, completely out of the blue, I calmed down. Alman Ali, a new face, has been declared Prefect. A certain Hassan Muhammad has been made Prefect of 9F.

'The Prefect of 9G is, MUHAMMAD ALI MANAN!'

I broke into a run, taking a sharp turn from the back and heading towards the front. The black framed steps appeared and my feet skidded through them, with which I jerked into a stroll to meet Doctor Nighat for the badge.

She reaches for the Mandate, embalmed on a silver plated badge which glinted in her hand, with a blue border encompassing it. The LGS Emblem, a miniature of the grandiose one on the lectern, bearing the words 'PREFECT' and 'MUHAMMAD ALI MANAN' pressed on to it, creating a depth on the markings. It was destined to be fixed onto my coat, and today, Providence smiled at me from the sky.

'But Ma'am, I'm in 9D', I begin, but she stops me. *'We will look into that later, Ali. Go down for now.'* I extend my hand once again, and start a series of exchanges with the teachers lined up at the right edge of the hall, Sir Hamid, Sir Nadeem, and Sir Imran, who was deeply buried in his own thoughts, thereby missing it.

Haad boiled over, with his jaw clenched and his fists tightened, and the atmosphere around him turning chaotic and blood-thirsty. I felt deep pity for him, since I knew he also signed up for Prefect, as well as Science Representative.

I did not have time to mourn for him, for the badge on Haadi's disproportionate chest gave me a fright. *'Mathematics Representative'*. Allegedly he got a B in Mathematics, albeit he was a devotee in the Robotics Club. To this day, I do not know how, or why he became Mathematics Representative back then.

We stood in ominous silence for hours. The hall was getting tense and the first few instances of slogans started, which startled us ninth graders. The hall slipped into a hush, holding its breath for a couple of other announcements.

'And the Council Head for this year is,' the silence broke, *'Muhammad Omer Nasir!'*

Omer Nasir, a Lilliputian student with braces, rectangular spectacles and messy, disproportionate hair coming forth with a multitude of badges on his coat already. Doctor handed over the most meritorious and crucial Mandate, Council Head, and she beamed while placing the new badge. We were awestruck.

We raised our right hand as the Oath was administered; '*I shall solemnly commit myself to upholding discipline, fair judgement, and the prestige of this Institution as a member of this Council,*' the official Council Photograph was taken, and we were instructed to return to the classes. I had my laptop with me in the Physics Lab, so I took my first picture with the badge instead.

Stepping into class with chants of '*Prefect Na-manzoor!*' rising from the far right corner of the class, I sat down amicably, took out my stationery box for the Maths lesson, and laid my eyes on the off-white wall bearing the softboards, a part of which caught my eye: 'لا تقنطوا' (*Despair not*).

Council Announcements were finally over. The sun of the 19th of February, 2024 was shining over a new world. A world where the strongest currency was the shiny grey rectangular coin bearing the crest of the '*Bank of Niggie*', as some dissatisfied elements named it. They had 'bid farewell and turned their heads away from the merits the Bank of Niggie had bestowed upon its Council Members,' which were to last till next February.

At least I had a badge on my coat after the Promised Day, but ten others also had it on theirs in the premises of 9D. There were two Prefects, the Culture, Chess, Library, Astronomy, Drama, Community Service, Alumni Relations, Robotics, and Science Representatives. There was a constitutional crisis, a Prefect-in-exile, a cataclysmic ignition of pandemonium, and yet, I was sitting as (maybe not for long) a Prefect. '*Mubarak ho sab Council walo ko!*' Sir Nadeem declared, bursting in for the next hour. I took off my coat.

I got the Mandate, but at what *cost*?

CHAPTER I

Genesis

Dad stepped into the garage. ‘Come out when you are ready,’ he called, as he headed to push the ignition switch of the car, with me sprinting outside two minutes later. Jackie laid down at the front door, covering the granite step as it demanded the morning ritual of patting it before going. It seized me for another minute, and it rolled up its tail like a doughnut again, accepting the tribute.

‘The Orientation would be a blast for you,’ he started, revving the car on to the main road towards the grandiose Pine Avenue. I smiled, albeit the spirit of transition in my apparel gave me worry instead of a stiff upper lip. It was yet another painful goodbye, along with the start of a new era as just one of the ‘newbies’.

August 21st, 2023. 9:18 AM. The sun smiled through the windscreen, reminding me of the lovely December afternoons I looked forward to during the Mid-Year Examinations throughout my life. The curvature of the subsequent square with a Turkish styled minaret showcased the majestic finial which served as a prism when the sun’s lower part was surrounded by it, like a hammock. Barricades, miniature gardens of lilies blooming and roses in the greenery of the road laid down above us, bushes dotted along the sidewalk, the world was on full combat readiness to receive change.

I remember the last transition a few years ago. COVID made things much easier, for online classes and exhibitions made it easier to immerse myself into the social spheres. This time, I was practically going empty handed. I knew none of the customs they had in that humongous building. The Principal, a certain Doctor Night, meant business, though the interview was pretty lively. The conversation

went on for 45 minutes, with Dad patting me on the back, saying: *'You nailed it. Good job!'*

The navy blue tinge was disproportionately present in the attire and I loathed that. A blue checkered shirt, dark blue pants, dark blue socks, I was accustomed to white and grey with a striped tie since times immemorial. I used to take pride in that, whether it was at the NHM, Atelier, BMTL, BGTL visits, anywhere. The last co-curricular year was when I shined, both in academics and events. One of the Council members in eighth grade also applied for the transition, but the smug Representative failed. I witnessed that and I was humbled.

Just then, the car screeches to a halt. The traffic just outside the school was a messy parade, as if a horrid incident had happened. Cars lined up on both sides, motorbikes swishing from the most awkward spots of the road, Dad heaved a sigh of relief as the car inched away from the apocalypse, and a decent area was vacant. He switched his phones off after peeking at them, and stepped out of the car. I followed suit, and we sauntered all the way to the A' Level gate at the other edge of the premises.

The towering red-brick fortress held us in arms with a red carpet leading other parents accompanying their children to a mysterious opening extending inside one of the buildings. We were surrounded by grounds galore, and at the other side, older children trussed up in black coats and light brown pants. 'I think we got the wrong uniform,' Dad thought, but other students, albeit younger, were wearing the same attire as I was.

A series of steps with red-granite treads and an elegantly curved nosing revealed a foyer diverging gracefully into two extensions with staircases on either side, encased in the red-brick walls with two bulky, dark-oak doors swung sideways and restrained by magnetic door stoppers. The commotion was upstairs and the contingents were being amicably ushered to the auditorium. We strided

into the grandiose entry for the Orientation Session and settled on the nearest seats.

The first thing I discerned after reclining was the sheer size of the swarm inside the hall, with even greater numbers of people coming inside. A group of senior students in badges and coats requests students to come and sit at the front, luckily they missed me. Regiments of such students were standing solemnly at either side of the hall, which was supported by colossal red-bricked pillars, bearing a gigantic ensign with a magnificent golden fringe hoisted at equal intervals, marking a unique perspective for symmetry. A babble diffused through the air which startled me as I took a deep breath.

Doctor Nighat proceeds to the stage and halts at a marvellously angled lectern bearing the school crest, on which she begins an address to the audience. The tiresome explanation supersedes a well-deserved standing ovation for a 'Life in JT' video earnestly prepared by the Media Society, giving a glimpse of the atmosphere, the accolades, the scenery, the feats, it did not fail to mesmerize me. As luck would have it, my phone beeps to reveal a notification. *'Hashim Chaudhry sent a message'*.

The bloke got in touch with me a few weeks ago, as he miraculously got to know that I was off for JT, to reveal that he was also getting admitted and he noticed me at the admission test. A chapter which was closed from the start of middle school reopened, and I almost forgot that he would be at the Session as well. *'Where are you?'* I asked.

'In the hall,' he replied.

'I know, but at what part of the hall?'

'Do you think I know the coordinates?'

'No, but still, where exactly are you?'

'I'm at the front, lol.'

A striking occurrence fascinated me as a senior student took hold of the podium and addressed the students. Adil Azfar, the then Council Head, gave us an assurance that JT is the epitome of integration, safeguarding the interests of the entire student body in the plethora of societies it boasts, and that he sympathized with our feelings as unripe, unsure students, pledging his support. The entire council, formidable and in unison, assembled at the stage for the parents to observe. It was remarkable that none of them twitched, signalling authority and the dignity they enjoyed.

The Principal returns to the stage again, announcing that the parents must go downstairs for refreshments and students would be heading to their classes. I decided that it was a golden opportunity to reunite with Hashim for once, before heading over to the Promised Land. The hassle took forever to die down, and once it was over, one of the invigilators from the admission test started announcing the names and sections of the students. I headed towards the front and sat down, after gazing at the decorations for the stage bundled with a few rows of spotlights.

'Hello', said a scrawny, oddly familiar but disproportionate, yellow being with braces on the teeth, brownish hair, sparkling brown eyes, too much facial hair and with the feeling that he had been stretched in a chewing gum machine like the unfortunate Mike Teavee from Charlie and the Chocolate Factory, as he sat next to me without any further reaction. 'Do I know you?' I said, after which he stares at me dead in the face for a minute.

'Ali?'

'Hashim?'

'You're...different.'

'Did you have a look at yourself mate?'

'Ummm, I'm taller than you.'

'Really? Stand up.' I retorted.

To his surprise, and perhaps mine, he stood with grandeur. I followed suit, only to discover that he was still, after all those years, shorter than me by a miniscule inch or two. *'Satisfaction'*, I thought, *'He still did not grow up from that third grade argument of who would stand before the other.'*

We decided to catch up with the developments during the past few years, appreciating each other's presence as Hashim's name was announced for 9E. He bolted, sprinting towards the stage with the rest of his class proceeding in a queue, leaving me alone as a stateless being. Students were laughing, sharing stories, moving back; the ruckus grew, and grew, until it became almost unbearable for me. I rolled my eyes in disgust, for my name was not announced till then.

My eyes rested upon the LGS emblem on the lectern, only to be intruded by the invigilator finally marking my allegiance to '9F'. I stood up, and strided towards the stage where a bearded student, with the grace of a nobleman, followed suit.

An outlandish voice rang in my ears, as the owner of it bellowed: *'Now, you must follow me and come to the class.'* An unexpected exit from the hall via another double door revealed a lengthy corridor extending to the unknown at a corner of the establishment, marked by flower pots and steps leading to another realm. The dwindling walls played host to a concatenation of showcases standing guard to trophies, accolades, shields, and medals by the dozen.

The mere sight of those ornaments enticed me to hang on, and stand in awe, but the procession took a sharp right, a flight of marble stairs with patches of gray and a bare railing, and a sharp left next to a soft board with a quote I was unable to decipher. Time ticked down without warning, as we settled down in the class.

I picked a seat and sat amidst total strangers, one of them having a beard, and the other wearing glasses with a sinewy build. The class bore signs of devotion, with notice boards and subject oriented materials running through the walls, a smart board attached to a computer concealed in an antique drawer, and the teacher's chair placed next to a compact podium, as the clock struck eleven.

'Welcome to Lahore Grammar School, Johar Town.'

'I am Tahira Iqtidar, your class teacher for this year. I welcome you again to this respectable establishment where rules are the key to the reputation we all enjoy,' she proclaimed, as she sat gracefully on the teachers' table, with her pink dupatta cast around her, and a black dress with a bouquet of all sorts of flowers patched on different areas. The croaky voice was justified, for she had wrinkles all over, strands of white hair and circular spectacles.

'Tomorrow, you will come to this class and have your lessons accordingly, do have a good look at the timetable attached at that notice board,' she pointed, diverting the class's attention to the elegantly laid notice board. 'Now, I suppose it is time for you to go downstairs, see you tomorrow!'

Thus, the Orientation ended in the twinkle of an eye. A mere half hour was all they needed for us to assimilate the school's expectations, towering might and the transition to O' Levels, with which they sent us going. The deafening silence of the entire class wrecked my circuitry apart, I heaved a sigh of relief when I stepped into the car and got back on my phone again.

An avid Ali woke up from my bed the next day, regardless of the circumstances the day prior. Fetching a watch from the bowels of my drawer, and a glistening packet of deep blue socks, I psyched up myself for the inevitable exposure to the New World. 'I hate going back to square one', I thought, while sauntering towards the O' Levels gate on the pavement joined with the school perimeter amidst a chaotic cavalcade of vehicles rummaging into every single bit of the road they could fit in.

Stepping into a new realm of the Promised Land, I was left in a fix. A new array of staircases, corridors, and landing points swelled from nowhere, with sprinkles of evergreen shrubs and bushes. I was in the depths of the unknown, not knowing where to start from, albeit I took the direction of the Hall as a reference point, sprinting through the staircase.

By sheer coincidence, I almost miraculously landed outside 9F the way we arrived yesterday. The melancholy bell prompts me to barge into class, though I stopped at my tracks to ask for permission. 'You are late', Miss Tahira began. 'I will not tolerate this from tomorrow onwards! Go and sit.' she blurted.

The bell screeches once again, prodding Miss Tahira out of the classroom's dominion and summoning a series of teachers throughout the day. Sir Javad, a plump, sunburnt and relaxed individual in an olive-green shirt and blue pants saunters into the classroom to speak on Numbers, our first chapter in the IGCSE Mathematics book.

'Remember to keep your notebooks neat, dear students. You get marked for that in your *results*! Now, speaking on numbers, we all know that the number one is quite a primitive and distinctive number, I must say. What factors do primes have other than themselves, one. What comes in every multiplication table, one. You see the number one in binary systems, right? Other than that, it is pretty special in belief as well. We, as Muslims, believe that there is One God! And...'

A hand shot up in the air attracting Sir's attention, which he acknowledges courteously. A high pitched, exceptionally clear and smooth voice responds, 'Sorry to interrupt, sir, but I'm Christian.'

An overwhelming majority of the class ahead sitting at the other half of the class swerves to examine the peculiar soul sitting at the corner of the class, next to the window, with lustrous, cropped hair, squared spectacles and a thin stature, who was addressed as 'Ayaan Romail' in the attendance segment at the start of the day, baffling my puny little brain as well. 'Ayaan, Christian?' I thought. It felt really weird for a second.

'Well, you also believe that there is one God, right?'

'Yes, sir.'

'Perfect. Now, the number one isn't prime, nor is it composite, note this down in your notebooks. One is also the least common factor for your information, but they don't ask about this in the exams since it is obvious...'

Filling pages with basic mathematical facts from middle school was not a hobby I enjoyed, but I still went with it. I was looking forward to the history lesson, for it was something which I held close to the heart. Enchanted by an in-depth study of Pakistan after 1947, which was where history in middle school always pulled the brakes arbitrarily, making my blood boil throughout the years. Foreign relations also remained a pleasant instance in the subject, evaporating the fatigue built up from the start of the day.

History was chocolate, and chocolate was my life blood, splashing through the veins. Just then, an unearthly, grotesque hag infiltrated, with a tip-tap of the heeled shoes pounding into the peace of the classroom. An eccentric colour scheme enveloped her unbalanced figure, crooked and chubby with the most awkward gait I witnessed in all of my fourteen years.

The face, an epitome of disarray, albeit I must restrain myself from commenting. It looked like she forgot to cleanse the face in the morning, with a sharp, macho ramus adding up to the disorder, and the buck-teeth serving as the cherry on top. My group was petrified beyond repair, as the being flumped, marking the start of the end.

'GOOD MORNING DEAR STUDENTS,' she bellowed, with a harsh intonation I could never forget, for memes exist. 'I AM SHUMAILA QAYYUM, YOUR NEW HISTORY TEACHER!'

I gulped. If this was the state of affairs in history, I would soon be dictated under duress, made to spit out what I did not believe in, and loathe history lessons to the extent that I would violate my own constitution. The lesson started with a general discussion of the Mughals Empire's decline, for which she duplicated a random book on the whiteboard, prompting us to follow suit on our

notebooks. Gestures of incredulity sparked throughout the class, with which she said: 'ON MONDAY, I WANT PRESENTATIONS ON THE DECLINE OF THE MUGHAL EMPIRE, YOU ARE FREE TO MAKE YOUR OWN GROUPS OF FOUR TO FIVE PEOPLE.'

The classroom broke into chats regarding the ludicrous affair clamped down by that horror-story of a woman, revealing the demographics. Three-fifths of the class was promoted from JTI, resulting in the continuation of prior friendships and associations. The rest of us were migrants from different schools, not knowing the rules of the game in JT. I turned towards the bearded man, revealing himself as Abdul Subhan.

We annexed a bespectacled, studious lad in white hair, Abdul Rafay, after which I asked from the well-built man, Ayaan Nawaz, about his current status in any group. We unanimously integrated him as well, and within the space of a mere two minutes, we exchanged numbers and wrapped up the problem of getting a team.

In the midst of these negotiations, a petite and angelic teacher, antithetical to Miss Shumaila in a sparkling red attire stepped into the classroom, introducing herself as Miss Memuna Naseer, our English teacher. She commanded respect, and the entire class fell into silence, as she declared, with a halting style in low-pitched serenity, 'I want *pin-drop* silence.'

A round of preliminaries continued, with which she turned around to reveal a straight mass of landmine hair dropping on the waist, as she scribbled through the entirety of the board with boatloads of full exposition dealing with the intricate nature of English Language in Cambridge, albeit by the end of the day, I was convinced that she made it harder. The mere mass of the specifications sucked the energy out of me, leaving me battered to the extent that I dozed off for a minute.

It was a literal abomination of a subject, reminding me of going to the showrooms to inspect and purchase a car or a computer shop for a laptop or a PC with the definite requirements, but even those were facile events. As luck would have it, the bell of freedom rang throughout the school, pulling us out of this catastrophe which drained our mental resources.

'*Ali, Ali, Ali,*' Ayaan Nawaz convoked, freezing me from heading towards the exit to liberty. 'We need to get this presentation done by Friday, I don't want this to linger on for the weekend.'

'*Alright,*' I announced. 'This will be the first thing on the agenda, I want it to make a good impression on this teacher so I'll send a drive link tonight. Everyone will feed in their info and I'll look after the aesthetics.' He smiled, shook my hand, and jogged to the miniature courtyard behind the gates. Things were finally getting along, our walking was going to make the track to progress ready in a jiffy, the transition was ready.

The teachers emphasized that it would take some time to get fluent with O' Levels, at least that was what they tried to explain with the paper patterns and introductory guidance, as the new Chemistry teacher, Miss Anam informed me. The journey was in safe hands.

'How was your first proper day of school Ali?' Mum questioned as I planted myself in the car, throwing my back on the other seat. 'Mum, not now,' I retorted, 'We just had a double-lesson for English and the teacher didn't spare a single bit of consciousness for the rest of the day. I want to sleep.' And these were the words I narrated in my first Urdu diagnostic which assigned '*My First Day of School*' as a topic.

'You know, Jackie. The day was pretty decent, my English teacher is too ambitious, and my Maths teacher is fascinated with lowest common multiples, now it's time to go back,' I declared, pulling the leash of a pearl-white creature with brown smudges over its fur back to the house...

CHAPTER II

Exodus

Miss Tahira called me out at the end of attendance on a fine September morning.

'Your name isn't in this list,' she declared, stone-faced.

My eyes grew wild with uncertainty. Some new faces had barged into the classroom, startling my mind but not enough for me to care about it. My heart throbbed violently, jumping into the throat, as I was forced to gulp. *'You need to check the lists outside the classroom doors, get it done quickly,'* she explained, witnessing the pale look on my face.

A gloomy sky besieged the red-brick fortress, dark grey with despair and with silver linings of hope scratched all over, serving as an audience to the unwilling departure I undertook from the class with my belongings. I never used the other staircase and the corridors adjacent to it, germinating this moment into a transformation. A series of genealogical charts, an elaborate chart of the eras of literature, and finally, a Council Board stopped me in my tracks. Pictures of all the Council Members were on public display right in front of the Coordinator's Office, a lifeless affair, bare as bone, with no one to give it life.

A charcoal-black computer was displaying the current time and the last student to swipe the school attendance card, revealing the hidden logs from the depths of its existence. Idleness bewitched the screen as it clicked, only to leave a dead, black mark over what was once ticking with life and energy. The dancing blue light rushing over the card scanner jerked to a halt, and a faint hiss bellowed from the bowels of the processor. The birds broke into a chorus of chirps, and like a shot, the computer sprang to life as if the chorus were a mantra to resurrect the contraption.

A sharp turn directed my trudging to 9G, and I decided to sneak outside and vehemently scrutinize the list. The dead centre of the list spelled my name out in its usual serif. '*Muhammad Ali Manan*'. Something from the inside tried to pull me into the alien realm, waltzing through the air around me, seizing every molecule nearby until I suffocated. I had no choice. I inhaled the impending future, exhaled the gloomy past, and started the journey of a thousand miles with a single step into a classroom, just a classroom – mind you – nothing more. An exchange of pleasantries preceded the attendance rituals, with an entirely new, obscure set of names.

'*I hear an accent,*' proclaimed the uncharted being to my usual '*Present, Ma'am*', who revealed herself to be yet another venerable teacher, but with a touch of serendipitous modernity. The short haired woman, frail but full of beans in a green-brown polo shirt was the literal polar opposite of the senescent dictator imposed in 9F, with tenderness radiating from her being. It was almost as if she was a beacon of life installed at the front of the class, the mitochondria with its classical definition; 'the powerhouse of a cell', the atmosphere engulfing the otherwise barren earth, the atrium of the establishment I was in.

I was taken aback by the mere enthusiasm, unwarranted and somewhat soothing as it was, for Miss Humaira Bhutto, as she introduced herself, was indeed an unconventional mentor, and to confirm my belief, she started a discussion on *theology*. *Theology*. A subject which had been taboo for most of my academic life, and an aspect of the arts I never paid heed to, but here we were.

A few hands shot up in the air when she asked for our responses, with the tallest one touching the skies belonging to a lanky, tanned figure in glasses who responded with a solid and definite response against the trick shot played by the woman at the podium. '*Thank you Ayaan,*' she says. '*Ayaan Nasser, I do agree with what you say.*'

The rear of the class hosted another tanned figure, a reversal of this Ayaan Nasser figure, albeit he was even more tanned. Sparks went through my temples. *Sparks*.

With a bushy beard, savagely huge hands and deep black eyes, he started uttering things from the literal abyss of randomness. ‘*Okay Haadi,*’ she proclaimed. It was very convenient to embrace the social structure prevalent in 9G without any direct conversation, and that is how I set up my boundaries. Ayaan Nasser, check. Muhammad Haadi, crossed out. ‘*Weirdo*’, I thought.

‘Everyone, send your numbers and your mothers’ numbers so that we can make the 9G boys and 9G mothers’ group’, Haadi remarked in the newly established Microsoft Teams class infrastructure. ‘*Mothers’ group*’, I thought. What, in the name of all good that existed, was the use of a mothers’ group when we had none since the dawn of Middle School?’ The mere childishness of the message was squirted from my existence as I spat in disgust. Haadi was *weird*.

It was lucky that the laptop shut down due to a low battery. My suspicions were confirmed. I did not need to look deep into the depths of the tomfoolery he so cleverly cooked. Jackie barked, and off I went to the realms outside.

Teachers had a profound attachment with presentations in JT, a fragment of the school’s so-called tradition, at least in the initial stages. ‘I want to see a presentation on so-and-so by Monday’, Sir Haris, the Literature teacher demanded. ‘It must have around twelve slides and this assignment will be marked as a part of your first sessionals in Literature, boys.’ The school had sessionals, an amalgamation of several continuous assessments instead of a full fledged Continuous Assessment Task (CAT) to bridge the gap between August and good old December.

My previous group in 9F was in disarray, as it endured a ruthless vivisection as the members, including me, were thrown into exile. Surveying the area the next day revealed Ayaan Nawaz who made it through the fragmentation, and an ebullient, striking and bony fledgling with silky hair and glasses and saucers for eyes partially concealed by rectangular glasses, featuring an Adam’s apple jutting out from his swan-like neck, with life leaking from his soul, dropping and flumping onto the marbled floor. He was speaking in a confiding voice to a

protuberant, pot-bellied *pygmy*. Both of these off-center beings had no need for disclosing their friendship to me, and I decided to butt in.

‘I think I want to work with you for that presentation, Haad,’ I suggested, after the preliminaries.

‘I was thinking of adding you in!’

‘Noice. Who else is on the team?’

‘We have Shehroz here and maybe I will add that guy sitting in front of you.’

Funnily enough, ‘that guy’ was none other than Ayaan Nawaz.

The sun shone over the auditorium building during our temporary relocation for the Sports Lesson. Shah Jee’s canteen was as empty as Pompeii. It had surrendered its life to the school timetable, begging me to stop by and buy something. The populace was engrossed in a football match, leaving me as a spectator with nothing to do on the frontline. I spotted a quaint realm, marked by a cyan bench and the quaintness molded by an enormous redbud tree dotted with white and pink flowers sprinkled like the black spots on a ladybird at the other end of the ground. Empty, chilly, and sunny, it drew me closer and closer to it.

Another figure, befogged by the distance stepped through the basketball court, in its screaming red and brilliant blue, guarded by basketball players. He sauntered through the thin, grey line of hope between the football ground, lush green in the afternoon sun boiling everything else, and the cricket pitch. His black hair, tall stature, and transparent glasses were now emerging in my eyes.

I took a sip of the apple juice. He sat down, looking at the march below us, and looked at the sunshine above. We talked, and talked about literally everything about 9G during the past week. Sir Abdul Rauf, our Maths teacher with a rectangular moustache and frail stature and a liking for rigorous Algebra had our approval. Miss Humaira Bhutto’s Urdu lessons were mostly free, she spent a neat bit of time explaining the importance of Urdu as a subject and what she had to do with us ninth graders.

‘I’m Ali.’

‘Asil, nice to meet you!’

First lessons on Mondays were reserved for the Assembly, if called by the Principal, or an extended Homeroom where class teachers were meant to assimilate themselves with their respective student bodies. Miss Bhutto strolled in and stopped in her tracks on a perfectly ordinary Monday. She studied the length and breadth of the room before her, filled with pairs of light-brown desks with black steel edges and legs, and thirty students in identical blue checkered shirts and deep blue pants perched on dark blue chairs with the weirdest curvature guaranteeing backaches. The thirty pairs of eyes looked back at her in utmost silence.

For two seconds, nothing happened. A second passed, then another second waltzed by. The air reeked of innocent puzzlement staring back at the old woman with ruffled, grey hair and a bottle-green shirt. In a flash, a student rose from the far-right corner of the class. The entire class followed suit, the chair rocked in rhythm, and within the blink of an eye, the woman found everyone on their feet for her, and her alone.

The woman’s face formed a pleasant grin in response, accepting the hasty tribute. ‘*Sit down*’, she announced, taking hurried steps to the front with its bamboo teacher’s chair and miniature podium waiting on their soon-to-be occupant. She pulled out a transparent case, bobbed a pair of fresh-grey spectacles and started the attendance procedure. ‘Ayaan Nasser Malik, Ahmed Ayyan Nawaz, Ahmer Hashmi...Muhammad Ali Manan, Muhammad Asil, Muhammad Haad Haroon, Muhammad Haadi,’ all the way to the end. ‘I have a pretty *humongous* load of things to do this year,’ she began. ‘Normally, I taught the tenth graders and the eleventh graders and it was well, but *this year*, they’ve placed me here.

Imagine having a thirteen year-old like most of you here,’ she began, scribbling on the whiteboard in the process. ‘Now, this thirteen year old is a student who has been exposed to Urdu since at least kindergarten. He makes squiggly letters through the years, and during those years, his Urdu teachers do

little to no effort in enlightening him with the elements. He knows nothing about the tenses, the complex notations, and the literal way of expressing oneself in the language.'

She then draws a stickman speaking in block letters: 'I HATE URDU. IT IS DIFFICULT.'

'Now this, students and the future "gentlemen of JT", is the problem. I need to make you guys love the language before we could say that the tree has finally borne fruit, and this is why I don't work like the other teachers. The other Urdu teachers are weirdos who hate technology and fail to understand the world today. They make the language boring, though it isn't, and you will have fun along the way.'

The bell erupted through her conversation, prompting her to leave. We looked at each other with numb faces. The woman had stretched this talk through forty whole minutes. By golly she managed to grab all of us while she spoke, and she had left us hungry for more.

Sir Rauf barged into the class and started his work while waiting for no man to catch up at first, and magically slowed down minute by minute until he was stuck with the front-row students struggling with angular work. He rubbed his moustache while peering at our work, and stopped for a second next to my desk.

'*You are?*' he paused.

'Ali Manan, *Sir*,' I replied.

'Keep up the good work!'

I kept on talking with Asil. Two and a half years later, I asked him quite a decent question, something I had meant to ask him for quite some time. 'Asil,' I began.

'How was day one of freedom?'

'Really good, what about you?'

'It was pretty decent. Asil?'

‘Yes?’

‘What was your first genuine impression of me?’

‘Should I be *honest*?’

‘Yes.’

‘Why the heck does this accented guy *talk* so much?’

I did not know I would find this man by my side at every single juncture I crashed into. I did not know that he would make it to the first row, but he did. We continued talking, taking occasional glances at the sunny ground where Rahim Usmani, Ali Tariq Niazi, Ayyan Nawaz, and Haad were prancing around with skin slick as oil, and the sweat beaded on their foreheads like tiny pearls. Ayaan Nasser and Haadi sauntered through the basketball court, having their own bit of fun. Shehroz was nowhere to be seen. The sun smiled at us as we decided to head towards class at the end of the lesson.

An empty basketball court with hues of red, blue, and yellow appeared before us. The library was empty. The hallways were empty. The stairs led us back to 9G. Those devilish stairs took the life out of us when we had to go up and down to the top floor from the ground, grey, wide, and guarded by student-made art on the walls of the red-brick lookout towers concealing the spiral leading directly to our class.

An almighty ringing pierced through the corridors, pounding into our poor ears as it sent shockwaves to the skull. The next lesson came knocking. I felt a push, and another push. Classmates swarmed from all routes, blocking the path to the door. ‘Open the damn thing,’ someone uttered.

The class door was—locked? A janitor with a brown beard rushed from the farthest end of the floor near the Coordinator’s Office, with a bunch of old keys jingling in his palms. He paused, rummaging his pockets once he scrambled through the entire keychain, unable to get hold of our class’s key. The entire class lined up behind the man, sweaty and miserable. In a brilliant stroke of genius, the man pulled out our key from his back pocket, stuffed it into the keyhole and jerked the door open. 9G was alive *once again*.

CHAPTER III

Warmongers

It took two seconds for someone to come. Ibrahim Kalim, a skinny Physics enthusiast, was about to form a really funny joke. ‘Good Morning Students!’ a voice from the farthestmost end began.

I was startled, for I did not know which lesson it was now. We all stood up to pay homage to a chubby teacher who stepped towards the lectern and asked us to sit down. ‘I am Anam Kamal and I am your Chemistry teacher this year!’ she began.

Two minutes later, she had us packing for the lab.

I had not cared to explore the school yet. The only parts I knew were the ground, our floor, and nothing else. We swerved through the marbled staircase towards the first floor, and took a sharp turn to the right. The ground was packed with people, and some of them had white A-Level shirts on. 9A came and went, with 9B alongside it. A deep patio materialised from nowhere, and vines sank from the top floor, draped with leaves, shrubs, and redbud trees at the base.

The vines surrounded the openings at three ends of the patio at our level, and windows were covered with wilderness at the fourth end. At the level beneath us, corridors appeared from all sides and the centre revealed an ornate, life-sized chess board with huge pieces charging at each other, and older students pushing those soldiers around the chessboard, capturing the other’s flank. A poem, information about quantum computing and cell formation eyed us as we looked into the desolate corridor at the edge of the school. An orange barrier, trussed up in gigantic locks from head to toe, and holes partially revealing the world on the other end, followed by a long walkway with two doors on either side,

and a tiny office at the edge of the peninsula sneered back. A partially bald, middle-aged man with a beard the size of Dumbledore's snoring on his waist which was at least a foot and a half long, and steel-rimmed spectacles guarded a door bearing the 'Biology Lab' plaque on the top. The Computer Lab was at the opposite side, with long workstations fused together in the antique square office lights flickering on them.

The Computer Lab reminded me of the first imbalance I suffered from during my ascension into the school. 'You would have to take Biology for a year in Grade 9, and after that we'll allow you to opt for Computer Sciences in Grade 10,' Doctor Nighat assured me in front of Mum and Dad during the interview. The books did not seem hard at first, so I had this inkling that one day I would study both subjects if I got the chance to do so.

We were directed to the Chemistry Lab, an establishment sinking towards the Assistant Coordinator's Office, with an array of blunt, grey experimental zones and tall, black columns with burettes hoisted up on them, sinks at either end of the desks, with four immaculate brown stools on either side and a huge contraption puffing fumes of smoke on the main desk overlooking its disciples. The board behind us was bare, dry as bones with no signs of life. The clock stared at the board, which stared at us. The scent of boxes and funny substances came waltzing through a small room at one end of the lab, and the rest of the edges were marked by windows and the familiar redbud trees around.

'Today, we will be starting off with chromatography, a method which we use to find out the substances present in a solute and their retention factors,' Miss Anam explained, smiling back at us. Even though it was a subtle experiment, drawing the origin, dripping a bit of ink, and placing the paper in a beaker full of some mysterious liquid printing colours onto the paper in the shape of a brilliant flame, we were pleased. She also got some copywork done, with which I went to her desk to get my chromatography paper and copywork assessed. She drew some red check marks and gave me a pleasant smile, shining and glowing with cheerfulness. The bell burst through the air and off we went for break time

downstairs. The sun shone over Syed Muhammad Imaad's hair as he walked out of the lab.

The ground was unusually packed at this hour of the day, with people in every nook and cranny of the premises. People from the previous 9F huddled together near the canteen. After meeting Ayaan Nawaz and Ruwaid, Haad came over for a visit.

'Decent day, right?' I asked.

'Yep!'

A grey tiled path surfaced through the football and the basketball sections of the grounds. The same benches where I met Asil were empty. I sauntered through the path, gobbling up my sandwich once I sat down. I waved at my cousin Zoraiz who was at the edge of the green football field. My eyes rested upon the pygmy, Shehroz, galloping all the way to my side of the benches. I closed my eyes until he was just a stone's throw away from me. 'Ahhhhh, what brings you here?' I asked.

'You know about the guy, Muhammad Haadi, right?' he asked, after the preliminaries. 'Yeah, I am not fond of him,' I confessed.

"That man is an abomination. A literal abomination. He is dark, darker than any force we might have witnessed, Ali. He's brought me to the extent that I torture myself. I torture myself. I scratch the hell out of my hands, he is nothing but toxic!"

Such were the words of Shehroz, zooming through the somewhat stationary world around me as his voice quavered, with his pulses struggling to come to life, sinking back into the throat as they jumped off. Strands of white hair on his round head caught my eye for the first time, as his protuberant belly dipped in response. His deep black eyes widened at the mere mention of Haadi, as he gulped twice: *'We need to get rid of him!'*

‘How? And what does that have to do with the rest of our class? He is a brat and I hate him for that. He is childish, but *why should I get stroked* with the cane intended for him?’

‘You have the ability Ali!’ he retorted, as he wiped off the mass of sweat on his forehead. ‘You can do something, you can! You are, in my opinion, the bulwark of 9G against that fitna (disorder). If we somehow manage to make power lean towards us, he will fall on the pillars he stands on! We could gather Haad and several others to create something against him. Ayaan Nasser supports Haadi, they’re very good friends, you know that he is the smartest kid around. *We must break their monopoly!*’

The depth of these statements made my puny mind take a sharp turn. A new wave of hatred splattered over my mind, as this fateful dialogue indoctrinated the masses of opinion in my head. If someone could make a person like Shehroz spend his nights in torture, he must be a crook. The hatred was more than raising black flags to mourn earnestly over the damage caused by Haadi, it was about Shehroz wanting to raise the dark-red, blood-stained cry of vengeance. Vengeance.

‘Alright, okay, Shehroz. I do think he needs to be dealt with. I have to visit the Coordinator’s Office. Bye! Let me go man.’

My pocket played host to an application for the removal of World History from my list of subjects, for one reason. The only reason for bidding it farewell was that it was after school, and I loathed that. Tuesdays and Wednesdays were, for me, the most brutal days of the timetable, for none but a single allotment of leisure, break time, was delicately carved on those sections. The Coordinator’s Office, an enterprise stamped right in the middle of the corridor towards the Old World, 9F, had none a living soul in sight, as always.

An unknown magnet pulled me towards the ground floor, the part which I had never fancied to visit and examine. However, an urge, boiling from the pits of my

mind, pointed me towards the mouth of a silent, desolate corridor guarded by plants which watched me as I climbed the miniscule staircase up to the red-brick building, my destiny for the next few years.

Somehow, my intuition brought me to the mouth of that corridor, which surprised me. It took me a while to get used to the directions of major landmarks within the school, with the library on the Ground Floor, something like Checkpoint Charlie between O' and A' Levels, with one corridor heading deep into foreign territory with men in white, and the same one plunging itself into our world. The library might have been the only thing both sides jointly occupied, where A' Level and O' Level students sat together to enlighten themselves under the watchful eyes of Shazia Yasmin, the librarian.

An invisible hand of the dark corridor beckoned me to pay reverence to it, pulling me closer, and even closer until I stood at the mouth itself. It was one delicate corridor, maybe the 'Atrium' of the building, and that is what I named it forever. The Atrium, of the heart, soul, and mind of the body I possessed for at least the next three years. The Atrium where I would sit for hours at end, contribute to the future, reminisce about potential alternative occurrences, witness change, and examine timelines.

As the Atrium caved into the heart of the building, a great, oak-wood double door emerged with golden handles guarded by a square fountain of Norwegian granite, reminding me of my kitchen counters with the same blue, grey, and cyan specks shining from different angles, reminding me of home. Water gushed through the pipe, dancing as it flooded the base of the fountain which was at the farthest end of the Atrium. Two rows of offices stood to my left and right, bearing silver plaques with two blue bars like those on the flag of Israel, one on the top and the other on the bottom.

The offices concealed many departments within them. A certain 'Waiting Room' had golden lights emerging out of the room, into the corridor.

The Waiting Room was basically the St. Peter's Square of the school at times, a fact which I experienced later on. The yellows of an unnamed storage room also snuck out of the door into the corridor. The Board Room, two Admin Offices and finally, two rooms bearing the Principal's plaque jutted out from the Atrium and the fountain in it. A board of Student Council Members with pictures of the Council Head, Adil Azfar, the Senior Prefect, Haziq Sheerazi, and many other alien people stared back at my eyes.

There was no ninth grader in the list, much to my confusion. A cabinet of trophies and accolades stood next to the A' Levels Admin Office right next to me, locked. Another corridor jutted out through the trophy cabinet into an area where the sun shone as if it were trying to stoop down into the school, and as I was about to depart, a voice seized the life out of my feet.

'What are you doing here?' Miss Lubna asked.

'Umm, I wanted to give an application to you but you weren't upstairs,' I replied.

'You could give it to the Admin Office,' she suggested.

I shot back upstairs, flinging myself through the corridors and almost bumping into Miss Asma Rafi, my Geography teacher, after handing over the application. and rushed through the murky entrance of 9G, only to witness Shehroz staring at me from the front row.

The walls of the class, which bore huge decorations of different subjects, mathematical theorems, the art of propaganda, prayers of mercy, an exegesis for a piece of Urdu Literature, all of them had fallen silent. It was literally gloomy, for the windows had banished all sunlight trying to barge into the room. An emotionless class featured an emotionless man, robbed of his vigour. With white strands of grief and dusty glasses, he looked at me with pleading eyes. 'So, what did you think? *Should we do something?*'

I was cursing myself for barging into a class which was none other than haunted devilry in that exact moment, but I had no other cards to play with. So here I was. 'Alright, *fine*. I'm in. They are idiots anyway,' I responded.

CHAPTER IV

The First Coalition

The pages of history always narrate how coalitions begin in the face of a common enemy. Few remember that Napoleon had invited the wrath of Britain, Austria, Prussia, the Dutch Republic, Portugal, and the Papacy. Fewer still remember that even these massive coalitions can be kicked back to where they came from, and indeed, people are human enough to forget what happens in long-drawn wars like these.

You never know how a die can be cast in the middle of a game. You can get a six, a five, a four, a three, a two, and a one. There is at least a sixteen percent chance for any one of these outcomes. However, life gambles with the numbers. It introduces a new variable which could turn the one into a six, or that same six into a wretched one. That, ladies and gentlemen, is what I call, by experience and upbringing, *divinity*. You may be of any religious denomination but you cannot ignore the role of this variable.

Haad Haroon, Muhammad Asil, and Shehroz Arif were my new chums. September was smiling, and October barged in. The trees had lost a bit of their lustre, from the ones standing guard outside school to the rickety old ones in the earthenware pots along the browned bricks of the entrance gate area. Seniors from other parts of the school used to force their way into the classes, appealing for event sponsors, support, and the like. Interesting things were trapped in the reins of the pitch, black depths of the earth. Crickets chirped deep into the corridors of the school, there was nothing serious to do.

The company of four sauntered out of class, picking their way down the marbled stairwell, with the paintings watching every single step they took. They slipped

through the mouth of the stairwell into the hues of the basketball ground, slicing through the mobs scattered in the grounds from the outside, while cracking jokes within their sphere. ‘Let’s sit here,’ I pointed towards the same benches I first talked to Asil in.

‘We need to get rid of Haadi and Ayaan Nasser, guys,’ Shehroz reiterated, as I reached for the farthest end of the benches just under the redbud trees covering us from the bare sun, ‘They have been gaining a lot of influence, especially with the teachers,’ he announced, looking first at Haad’s puzzled eyes, then Asil’s spectacles, and finally, my face. We agreed.

9G was ripe for good old revolution, in its literal sense. Inciting the masses, collective ostracisms, and schisms behind the scenes, Shehroz loved the bit of history I introduced in our ‘struggle for *righteousness*’. Asil talked at great length about the possibilities where Haadi could outsmart the plebian minds. Haad talked about how he hated Miss Bhutto’s attachment with Haadi’s, which was second only to Ayaan Nasser’s. We spoke our minds out, erroneous, doctored, and somewhat imprudent minds concocted by one amongst the four.

I spoke so much that I did not get time to even lay my hands on lunch for the day. Shah Jee’s partner, the famed Baloch, threw an apple juice at me which I caught the way one catches a ball in cricket before I dashed back to class. Our Physics class was a minute away, prompting me to skid through the staircase into good old 9G.

I was late, but the man at the front had just entered as well. He was stocky, with fat wrists and rectangle glasses which shone as he chuckled with Muhammad Haadi, who happened to be sitting at the front that day. Ayaan Nasser Malik recalled that when he first came to 9G from 9B, he was amazed by the vivaciousness bubbling out of class the instant that man entered class. I was in the same boat.

Sir Hamza Arif, as the man introduced himself, broke into laughter halfway through his name when Haadi whispered something anxiously. He rubbed his

mane of a beard, as he glanced at the ceiling. His head swerved towards the rest of the class and he took a deep breath to swallow the laughing gas.

‘Guys we have a Robotics Society on Tuesdays and Thursdays for LEGO sets, and the Coordinator has opened registrations for those. I highly recommend joining as it’s pretty convenient to develop skills which could develop an interest in this field!’ he announced.

I was already convinced to join the second he enunciated the word ‘Club’ from his mouth, for I sensed a moment of true adventure. I was starting a journey of a thousand miles, and nothing, even the subtleness of the class at that moment, was enough to deter me from my aim: *Robotics*.

Physics ended with Sir’s final treatise on the laws of motion, and his left-handed masterpieces; speed-time graphs which made no sense. He stomped through the podium, changing his gears into a waltz as he smiled back at us when he was an inch away from the door. Finally, I got to know about a community which was filled with people who thought like me. It was the relief I was desperate for in the weeks preceding this moment; relief, no matter the temporary nature, from the Biology dilemma I was suffering from.

Miss Sabah Mehmood took over every Wednesday morning, huddling us towards the Biology Lab with the famed Dumbledore-styled lab assistant. He was chopping potatoes and flipping them around on miniature tiles when we barged into the establishment next to the Chemistry Lab. ‘Today we are going to examine these cells under a *microscope*!’ she cheerfully announced, pausing for approval. Adil Riaz Warraich, Khudadad Chattha, Musa Raza, Zaid Raufi, none of them smiled. She took a deep breath while fixing her glasses. She tutted at the whiteboard, which carried remnants from the previous class.

The sun shone into the lawn when I stepped inside after a long day at school, which had sucked the literal soul out of me that day. Jackie barked in joy, as he galloped towards its longtime companion. I smiled, patted its furry white

head, and stepped into the welcoming Persian bit of the lobby with its blacks and yellows.

I have no idea what I was thinking about, but I went straight to my laptop at the farthest end of the house. I rummaged through the Start Menu for WhatsApp. I searched far and wide, from the bustling metropolis of the Family Group, to the depths of the caves where my friends from JTC lived.

‘*Group created!*’ WhatsApp smiled, two minutes later.

‘Gentlemen,’ I began, ‘no one likes censorship, and I admit I can’t sit back and let them *scrutinize* the hell out of everyone’s conversations. You all can use this group to chat!’ I boasted, scrolling through the member lists to make Haad the admin. Ibrahim Kalim sent a picture of Dora the Explorer in a moustache, with the title ‘*Ali Manan right now.....*’

‘*The price for democracy,*’ I thought, ‘*is that the initiator of a democratic regime, or the leader of a revolution, is the first to be martyred by the spears of public opinion, like Mujib.*’ Nevertheless, my drunk mind did not care to think about the possible effects of trying to counter Haadi’s hegemony in the class group, kicking people around whenever he felt best, sending night pictures of the school in the group chat to strut about his involvement in Lumina that year, and so on. I decided to go on. Haad and Syed Muhammad Imaad, a frail bloke with the shiniest hair I know, both approved of the new regime. Shehroz had argued with Haadi so it was quite natural that he would show up in the group.

I have no idea what I thought. The most possible conclusion I can faithfully concoct while lifting my pen, is that I often thought of myself as the promised Messiah of all sorts. I was quite thick-headed when it came to long-drawn wars, and it is quite certain that this trait of mine back then defined most of my engagements with the ‘*dictators*’ of the class, but I had an enormous list of things to worry about back then. Each era has its own troubles, slow poison which melts the liver through years of conspiracies bubbling along the veins.

‘HERE ARE YOUR MARKS FROM THE HISTORY TEST,’ Miss Shumaila Qayyum bellowed the next morning, pulling me back from the fantasies I dreamt of in class. She shoved the responses on our desks, parading through the gaps between columns of desks dotted around the class.

‘She gave me a 5 out of an 11, and she didn’t teach us how to *write* a damn question,’ I hissed, restraining myself from swearing under my breath. Two arguments occurred within class due to the scores but she did not give a tinker’s toot to what we had to say. ‘YOU HAD TO STUDY’ was her only reply which she struck us with, the way shrapnel strikes a soldier on the battlefield.

The classroom held its breath like a small bear which could smell coups from miles away. All pairs of students attempted to console each other, except for Ayaan Nasser, who sat silently, looking at the door. Shehroz looked like he was about to cry his eyes out. Asil was grieving. Haad’s temples were twitching, and so were the temperaments of others.

‘We could do a *petition* against her,’ I suggested, smiling in the midst of the masses lamenting the way they do at funerals. ‘She is not going to get away with all she’s doing, throwing presentations on us, and doing all sorts of weird stuff. We need signatures from other classes as well, and then we will see what happens!’

‘Other classes hate that idiot as well,’ someone from the front of the class announced. ‘We can easily get fifty signatures in about a week and end the debate *here!*’

You can see where this is heading. This was yet *another* time where I became the Messiah due to a bright idea and the ability to say it out loud. These things were valued in those days of yore, which made people smile. The blighter had taken a presentation where she deducted marks in the name of noise from conspirators unknown. She spoke in the weirdest accent known to mankind, enunciating the epithet of Mohsin ud Din, *Dudu Mian* with the reverence the mullahs have for holy figures. Whenever she spoke to me, her Kashmirs changed into ‘cashmeres’ and oh God, the slanders and memes of the time made by Hamza

Cheema and Ibrahim Kalim always clear the fog of the lenses I had for that era.

‘Yes, I know, she is a bit loud in the staff room though she doesn’t realize it,’ Miss Bhutto comforted us in the next Urdu lesson. ‘I hope you guys could see an improvement in relations between her and your class.’

She was unaware of what had been set in motion. A masterstroke of my famed legalese came into action, which was going to have a profound impact on many things, at least surely in the career of the woman teaching history to the ninth graders:

‘We, the undersigned, hereby table a motion against Miss Shumaila Qayyum on the following issues which have interrupted our day-to-day proceedings:

Unfair time division in a marked presentation.

Unjustified deduction of marks in a written assessment.

Difficulty in understanding the concepts discussed in class.

Use of inaccurate chronological facts.

No informed marking scheme and pattern.

We would sincerely request an acceptable solution for these issues which have been causing us a grave inconvenience.’

It was ready.

Hashim Chaudhry met me a few silent days later after 9G, during which the document had to go through elaborate processions from one class to another. ‘I will not sign until this document gets at least fifteen signatures, *Ali*,’ he confided. I did not lose my resolve for the petition even with this setback. Another round of processions occurred, and finally, the number of signatures reached forty-nine. The hour of action had arrived, flaunting its hand around those who sought to seize it. It was the point where only God knew what could happen *next*.

CHAPTER V

Around the Levant in Eighty Days

Rusted memories circled through my mind, swinging my eyes to and fro. There was another situation in the Levant, which was more brutal than anything the folks at BBC had witnessed in these past few years. There was always a void in my mind between 1922 and 1990, which I never cared to map out, only to think about mapping it after those fateful strikes against both states involved.

The Robotics Room was perched at a barren corner of our building, with only one route like the Western Desert Extension in the midst of the barren Egyptian front against Rommel, leading into a cavern torn out of the building by a lion of some sort, the wounds of which were covered by the same grey-white marble tilework of the stairwell, black metal frames sealing a part of the wall, and a chunk of landing with a jammed stairwell at one end, and a mystifying brown door with a battered, needlelike handle locked from the inside at the other.

The stairs on the first floor, just a stone's throw away from the long cabinets with the dozens of awards, spiralled you up to another bit of landing in front of a double-door paving the way inside. It was nothing but an observatory separated from our own second floor by a huge vent stimulated by the corridors and the giant hole in the first floor which you could look down upon.

The room trenched deep into another indefinite part of the school, stretching towards a typical classroom whiteboard guarded by two quaint, towering cupboards with black, brick-like kits, old Thinkpads, wires, bits of robot, circuit components, voltmeters, red ammeters, and compartments for the specifics of Arduino robots, soldering wire, soldering equipment, Sir Hamza's

personal miniature car and battery charger, and a lot of paraphernalia I cannot remember.

A long array of tables and chairs were lined up at either wall, with a taped quarter of the room reserved for testing line followers in both LEGO and Arduino sets. Sir Hamza's desk directly overlooked the tracks, and the bland clock stared at every single exploit taking place in the lab's bounds. Hashim's dark hair fluttered into the faded glass panes of the double doors at the start of the lab, sniffing around to ensure there was nothing harmful inside. He pushed the door ever so slightly, after which he paused in his tracks.

'I think we should become a pair,' he suggested.

Agreement was the only choice I had, for it was our first activity after the years of distance we trekked through. Hashim pulled out a battered Windows 10 laptop hanging from a clip, which took ten whole minutes to start up. Crumbs and gunk were marinated all over the poor thing, which was hanging onto a rusty hinge for dear life. It took another ten minutes for the wretched contraption to even download LEGO Mindstorms software on it, and when it finally did, the app *stopped working*.

I had an Acer from COVID which was gone for repairs, but that bloke was not the sort of thing I wanted to bring to school for mounting almighty cannons on. I had already struggled to push that sleek thing into the laptop pockets of my old bag in Middle School. If the duo was to survive, the laptop problem, something which threatened the mere existence and progress of our duo, had to be sorted out. 'You can wait for next month and I'll get you the one they've freshly made with a twelfth generation core from out there,' Mum argued.

'*This is my sister's laptop*,' I remembered Hashim explaining. I wanted the duo to survive and literally, within the next forty-eight hours, Mum shook a tote bag around the air, enticing my hands to take hold of it while she talked on the phone. I found a shiny, mint twelve-inch work laptop buried in that bag, a fruitful, yet hasty result of my adamant soul, waiting anxiously for its owner.

'Check the specs and take it to the next Robotics Session,' Mum announced. Dad continued driving. The duo had been saved, at last.

Banners had sprung up, glistening in the twilight upon its reds, greens, blacks, and whites, colours of Fedayeen and watermelons, gliding from the desert on the third floor – barren except for humungous solar panels forming a ramp in the sky – to the tip of the ground floor where an oasis jutted out of the entire building. 'Donations for humanitarian support can be submitted to both the O' and the A' Level Admin Offices,' the Head Boy announced to the crowds a half-hour later.

Submissions to the Magazines were thrown open for the Palestinian cause, with the editorial dedicated towards the Gazan cause. It was an astounding sight, people had started theming themselves in red, green, and white. It became quite normal in the next few weeks to find the Palestinian flag on someone's chest. 'Say no to occupation, say no to racism, say no to manslaughter!' banners around the school cheered with the masses.

The crisis had, though it is often perceived as little, a *lot* to do with us here, thousands of miles away. The boycott of all 'Israeli' goods had taken its toll. You were not able to eat Lays chips in front of everyone, open a can of Coke, or think about McDonalds and KFC without side eyes and judgemental whispers.

It was for a good cause, however, we did not realize that we were still using technology from companies which allegedly supported, either directly or indirectly, what academics around the world had started considering a genocide. Everyone had Instagram stories about Palestine and Israel up in their private accounts. The next couple of MUNs featured debates on the recent occurrences happening at every nook and cranny of the land, from Gaza City to Khan Yunis to Bethlehem to East Jerusalem to Hebron to Haifa to Tel Aviv. The land of the three great religions was drenched all over in the blood of its Muslim, Christian, and Jewish inhabitants. It lingered on, and the horror still remains today.

The Environment Society's Senior Representative, Mujtaba Imran, showed up in class to announce 'an environmental class project, where each class will make a model of a sustainable community.' It took two seconds to mobilize and bring in reinforcements. The people, Adil Riaz, Shehroz, Ibrahim Kalim, and all these people rolled up their sleeves with Haad the next day. They squished and spread the modelling clay all over a styrofoam sheet. I tried pitching in, painting parts of the clay and so on. Ayaan Nasser stood up and tried to assist as well, but Haadi? He treated the workspace like a hub for the *Untouchables*.

Yet, he was the first to struggle for a place at the front of the crowd, someone who loathed any other hand which had been raised for volunteering. He kept close contacts with teachers, eventually getting the phone numbers of most of them, while keeping the news of events and applications hidden. Throughout the month of October, I noticed his urge to become the spokesperson of thirty other people, thirty people who had wildly different minds, with approaches that were the polar opposite of what he practiced. Those ideas were bound to be nothing but literal horror for that bearded man.

In retrospect, the shot heard around the world came in a quiet afternoon when the leaves fell, which had stood with utmost valour against the cold earthly winds from the west. *M. Haadi removed Rehan Rashid*. The predicament – satire aimed at the bearded man. I was unaware of the bloody hammer which struck the poor guy's beard whenever someone uttered a word of sarcasm in his group chat. He was never available in private messages, and that was how he had his *chips*.

Literature was something I had started to fancy. The *Vodkanama*, an amalgamation of *vodka*, a classic Russian symbol, and the *Baburnama*, was a purely satirical and cultist bit of text I concocted to denounce the bearded man. It was the classic battle between liberals and conservatives, and even though that text has been lost to history, 'King Ali' advised 'Fuhrer Imaad' as follows:

'Lo! Obey thou mine own philosophy, for 'tis more true than the fascisms of Mullah Haadi. He shall offer his Shabbat in Ramallah, for he is a hypocrite of the

unjust state. Shouldst thou begin thy resistance against this unjust creature, he will run off his left foot and flee to the Wails of the Wailing Wall. Thou shalt be in confusion, “Who is this Haadi?” Lo! ‘Tis Muhammad Haadi, the child with a beard, none but counterfeit!’

‘Lo! Thy Comrade shall strive for all Vodkaland, and that thy class shall be his capital city! Hark, men! The Mullah is not to be trusted, for he shall prove a fascist. And O Comrades! Forgive thy Comrade-in-arms if he hath committed an unwelcome sin, for thy Comrade is thy Comrade, until he hath committed a proven indecency ‘gainst the people.’

Our class was now nothing different than the Levant. We had all sorts of folks living in Beirut. However, there were three main, loosely stitched groups of people. You had those who supported Haadi. Then you had some chums who decided to rebel, and then there were the spectators who leaned to either side depending on their mood. One call of action was enough to absolutely decimate the peace of our social sphere, and funnily enough, Miss Bhutto had no clue, at least that is what we thought.

Now is the time to introduce a very special character in this context. A character who decided to grow a beard like the great Mullah the year after the hatchet was buried. A man who spent time listening to both sides, but acting as the first proxy between the two sides: Jaanzaib Hamid Mukhtar, a diehard fan of B. R. Ambedkar, poet, political analyst, and a ‘silent observer’ of everything. With moles all over his face, the messiest side-beard I have ever witnessed, and protruding eyes, he always came over to visit the *Comrade* (me) at the redbud tree, famously known as *AMP*.

‘Well, Haadi thinks you are this weird man who causes fitnah throughout the class and he has been worried since you like inciting the masses and your “communism” makes them think you are pretty non-religious,’ Jaanzaib remarked after appreciating the intellectual fruits Miss Bhutto’s Urdu class had borne and poetry,

which he was an ardent admirer of. ‘What is the etymology of this *AMP*, you have it everywhere now!’ he questioned.

People throughout JT force a bewildered look when they hear the word AMP. ‘What is AMP?’ they say. ‘Ali Manan Pasha, Ali Manan (something I can not mention here), or what?’

Let it be known that AMP was my username on my Meta Quest. While setting it up with the old Oculus Account system that had existed back then, I had to choose a name for myself. The first thing that waltzed in the lanes of my mind was *Ali Manan Private*. Since then, it has become my alter-ego, and in JT, it transformed into this unearthly cult of personality, the way Muhammad bin Salman’s initials are quite popular in the press. 9G knew me as a Red, a far-left fanatic who could rant about history, politics, and the like. Thus, the *AMP scare* was born.

‘I think we should cease hostilities as we are polarizing the class,’ I remember telling the Mullah in November while stepping into the red-brick tower, and the landing of the marbled staircase. ‘We have two groups of people and none of them are prepared to even cooperate with one another. We have two WhatsApp groups now. It’s quite painful.’

‘Yes, but that is supposed to be the fault of the man who made the second group!’ the Mullah slyly smiled, as the chocolate pigment of his eyes manifested in the sunlight pouncing through the barred holes stamped into the tower. He climbed the stairs and sat on the sill, sipping mango juice and forming another one of his malignant smiles.

The last ditch attempt to save the precincts of 9G from falling apart had failed. He shunned his role in the entire conflict and decided to let time sort things out. Alas, he asked for walls to be built in the middle of our city. ‘*We are not going to involve the Mullah in our plans and teams,*’ Shehroz and I unanimously declared. The tanks had started lining up on either side of the wall, with no intention, let alone sign, of turning back to their peacetime bases.

CHAPTER VI

Warren Peace by Leo Tolstoy

Yes, decline approaches after a lengthy period of intense stability and satisfaction. In fact, nothing much happened throughout the first term during the ‘Great War on the Mullah’, ever since we had established the conditions of that war. There were some occasional skirmishes at the borders, and some messengers including Janzaib trying to proselytize the other’s view.

‘For the yearly Science Project,’ Sir Hamza began in the deafening silence of the morning hour, ‘you have to submit the names of your teams by tomorrow. The presentations for approving the project would happen next month, and these grades are a part of your results in the Mid-Year and Final Year Examinations. The exhibition, however, will happen in the second term.’

My eyes raced through the length and breadth of the class. Asil was already talking to Raahim Usmani, a stubby football player, and the look on his relaxed face with the snubby nose was quite obvious. *He was in.* Haad dozed off next to me, and Shehroz was giving me the stare which quite plainly meant: ‘We are going to be one team.’

‘This guy as well?’ I pointed towards the bony contraption next to me with no worry in the world, surfing through the sea of his own thoughts, drowning in the chocolate of his own eyes. Shehroz stomped through the class and plonked on the chair at my front, eyeing Haad. ‘We can become a team and I have asked Ayaan Nasser to be in our team.’

I was on the verge of vomiting after this revolting idea rang through my poor ears. ‘Are you daft?’ I spat. ‘He loves that Mullah and you are bringing him to an affair

that would cost us a grade and our reputation as students in front of the Science folks.'

'No!' the two balls of play-dough gurgled. 'He is good at science and he is bound to listen to us as well, because we are joining our grade with his grades! If he does something, he'll just be shooting himself in the damn foot!' Haad was convinced by those two balls of play-dough. My opposition was in vain.

Sir Hamza led the march to the Physics Lab in earnest. The vines of the redbud trees stretched all the way to the individual pieces of the life-sized chessboard in the basement the way a child tends to lean towards the front while carrying a heavy schoolbag. Bits of fresh vines were being pulled by an unknown hand, perhaps of the wind, into the corridor outside the lab complex. The vines rustled into the void again, suspended by a dangling branch which kept the heinous mouth of the void below from swallowing its prey, condemned to watch them prance around from the farthestmost edge.

Miss Bhutto's talk was unusually directed towards the ongoing distrust and radicalization of our class. Haad and the two balls of playdough stared at the old woman with eyes the size of teacups. Shehroz tried to form words with his eyes, but Miss Bhutto broke: 'A house divided within itself *cannot stand*.' The Nasser-Mullah edge of the class formed weak smiles, weak enough to infuriate me from within. '*If they were so blissfully happy then why can't they even smile properly?*' I wondered. Their diplomacy was as hypocritical as their actions. They had gotten us, two to nought, running scot free from the Environmental Management Project by shoving the work aside and standing at the front of every arrangement.

'We would be doing a project on Mycelium!' an exuberant Haad Haroon announced the next morning. 'It took me two hours to think about this and I think that we could pull this out and make this a good deal of a project, and we will make sure the other ones look puny enough on the face of it!' he added.

‘Yo ChatGPT,’ I smiled after entering the precincts of my house with the sun spying at me through the last window of the entire house, in my room, its smile glistening to the black clock in the lounge aligned in harmony the way constellations are. I coughed and took a deep breath. ‘Give me ideas for a science exhibition coming up in school. What should I pick as the topic for my project? Give me some decent and unique ideas because I want to impress my teachers.’

‘You could work on mycelium Ali!’ the bot stuttered. ‘It is a project where you can think about its properties of decomposing oil, that process is called mycoremediation,’ it proudly suggested. I let out a laugh. ‘What happened?’ the cook asked, bursting through the kitchen door.

‘Nothing, nothing, can you make me a paratha?’

Something quite peculiar had happened that day in the break, one of the most peculiar things I have experienced. I had just gobbled up my sandwich and I was ready to go chat with some people in class. Ayaan Romail crossed the basketball court with another figure, tanned, with a bit of sidebeard and dented teeth. ‘Ayyyyyyyy, Romail!’ I cried out while shaking his hand. ‘Tell him the Iris story as well!’ Ayaan looked at the other figure who looked back at me.

‘Alright then!’ he chuckled, ‘but we need a place to sit!’ We finally shortlisted the area within the O-Level gate and the main building after a few minutes of ‘uhhmm’s and ‘noooooo’s at the stairs curving towards Shah Jee’s canteen, a hole in one of the many towers of the school.

The rear of the school bathed in a tub of afternoon daylight, yellowed from its head in a small room at the end of one wall, to its feet at the start of the stairs. A huge shed over the gate carved out the ribs of the creature we were going to sit in, breathing in the breeze that had extended from the west through its countless flowers, shrubs, bushes, and trees at the rims thickened with a once red-brick wall now smiling in muddy brown. Almost as if someone had bewitched the heart of the space below us as we stepped down the marbled stairs into the feet of the breathing necropolis, half a dozen of circular platforms lined in grey slabs,

and the same red-brick motifs rose from the otherwise dead landmass we had entered. It was perhaps the first time I had noticed the presence of fans standing guard under the shed, which featured circular tables with blue benches mounted on them, resting at the sides like a pet does in the presence of its owner.

‘We have an English teacher in our class and his name is Sir Imran Khaliq. He’s a very chill person and...’

‘He’s from 9D,’ Ayaan Romail explained. Rayan continued. ‘He was ranting about his time with the British Council et cetera while he was training to be a teacher,’ the tanned figure began. ‘Yeah, so, he was telling us about how he met this Iris person who had somehow been attracted to him, but she did not know that the guy was married with two kids already!’

Ayaan Romail fixed his square glasses and brushed up hair as he sighed, having to listen, or pretend to listen, to the entire affair once more. The conversation cycled towards only one topic – Sir Imran. ‘This mysterious teacher was a magnet for the women around him, a ladies’ man,’ I thought. The topic was a bit too mature for a thirteen year-old back then, but we both kept on paying heed to the emissary.

‘Our class is fun as hell Ayaan,’ the boy continued. ‘We have this kid called Dayem Salman, and he somehow managed to get his finger stuck in that keyhole where the lock is supposed to be on the desk!’ He burst laughing from his insides. We chuckled in return, with an image of a child trying to squirm his finger out of the desk flashing before my own eyes. Somehow, I could form those images without a great deal of mental effort.

‘Yeah, so it was our Maths lesson and the Math teacher was doing his business and all was well until he took a tour to Dayem’s desk when he saw that Dayem was not doing his work, unlike the others. The old guy stepped towards the table and Dayem was literally hiding that hand of his. “Where is your hand?” the teacher asked, and Dayem had no choice but to reveal the secret he had tangled himself in.

They literally had to call the custodians and they would’ve sawed the desk’s part,

but one of them had the bright idea of bringing oil from the storage room and lubricating the areas around the finger with it. He had to literally wriggle his finger out and it came with the weirdest possible sound it could have come with,' he narrated.

'Why in the name of God would a teacher talk about this stuff in school with ninth graders, and why would someone fiddle around with that hole?' I blurted, while laughing through the ordeal. 'He's a different sort of guy,' the man clarified! The conversation went on and it would have stretched to the night, if it were not for the bell blasting through us at the right time. 'I'm Rayyan Fahmeed by the way, you are?'

'Ali. Ali Manan,' I smiled.

'You're that *political guy* in 9G, right?'

The Mullah had a lot of cards up in his sleeves. This entire stupidity was supposed to stay within 9G. Now, it had gotten out of the bubble, but that was the least of my concerns at that particular minute during the sunset. I decided to take over as the de-facto leader of the project's affairs. 'Someone add Syed Muhammad Imaad here please,' I messaged.

A week later, at the end of the day, I sauntered through the gate and kept on talking to Shehroz, while pulling myself out of the cascade of men, women, and children from other schools arriving to pick students which grew into an enormous mob stretching into the main street. 'Shair Khan' was completely surrounded by a mound of chaos. The greys of cars parked at either side of the road had disappeared, and people had started lining up against the scraps of dilapidated rural buildings at the other side of the road with its inhabitants struggling to park within their properties, with a rusty crucifix mounted on a building the colour of sand hurling curses at the masses below, and broken balconies cast upon parts of the narrow stretch of road.

'Well, we have this project my guy, and we need to do something about it because

I am not going to sit back and let people reap the benefits of a team project while doing nothing,' I confided while taking steps towards the corner of the school at the junction between the narrow road and a somewhat wider one. He struggled to keep along, so I slowed my pace, 'Ayaan Nasser—'

'For the love of all good that exists, keep that child in the classroom, you both!' someone interjected from the back. My throat dried up and out of the blue, my feet lost every bit of power to move forward. Shehroz took a second with me to take a breath and turn back to witness the meddler and give them a piece of our minds, only to find – Miss Humaira Bhutto *herself*.

Our class teacher.

I guess we had literally driven her up the wall by just mentioning Ayaan Nasser outside the classroom. Yes, we had *reasons* to loathe him and likewise, he also had the same sentiment. However, we were not projecting any of that hatred outside the school, but I saw her blood silently boiling through her veins whilst she stood there with aching temples, in her usual frizzy hair and red shirt in the afternoon heat.

'I think you should *leave* matters of the classroom within the bounds of the classroom and hold your peace outside, and bury school matters within those four walls before coming out,' she shot, before taking a deep breath, which translated to 'I think you both are idiots,' and stomping away to her car in the depths of the unknown.

'Now she is going to think I am involved in all of this and now I am cooked,' Shehroz uttered bitterly before bidding an uneasy farewell.

Nasser was, in fact, a smart cookie with lots of chocolate chips stamped on the top, but we did not know how the process of cooperation would begin, and how it would inevitably bid us farewell, and I knew that the path we were on was going to have some side-effects, one of which I had witnessed in its fullest. Silence continued to ache into the sunset the way it ached after this exchange. It was *over*.

CHAPTER VII

December Syndrome

Mendeleev's table marked the advent of Saturday morning for me in the most usual fashion. Some light revision in the lounge, breakfast, Minecraft, some more studying, and VR was what I had planned for the weekend. A pleasant, quiet weekend after a monstrous mound of 'What is going to happen next week?' and 'Is all of my classwork done or would I be screwed on Monday?'

'School Office 364-OL has made an announcement!' Microsoft Teams blurted.

I might have been a dullard but I knew one thing: you should never expect good times to always last, even if they loaf about with the illusion that they do. It makes bad times startling – so much that often your first response to such a crisis is burying your head in the sand like an ostrich, while praying that the sandstorm is over. You die in the attempt.

Picture this: you are sitting on the kitchen table in the morning and there is an absolutely enormous mirror in front of you giving a clear view of the emptiness behind you. You have a glass of apple juice in your hand and the door to the lobby on your left is open, letting the morning sun of the eighth hour sneak into every nook and cranny of your house. The glossiness of your yellow floors reflect sunlight into a black clock standing guard over the lounge you're sitting in. Your laptop is to your right, and you have the red IGCSE Chemistry textbook in your left hand. No one other than the cook is awake who is making breakfast.

It is in fact, quite obvious that you would pause, for many a minute, to pull yourself out of the weekend frenzy to even think of clicking the dreaded purple notification at the bottom-right corner of your screen. You pause – for a minute, then another minute, and yet another. You are oscillating between two

radical opinions: listening to what those folks had to say so urgently on a Saturday morning or shun their appeal of your attention. The former is perhaps what most sane people would prefer, and unfortunately, I was barmy at that hour.

‘Dear Students and Parents,’ you read, praying that it is a normal notice and nothing alarming, ‘this is to inform you that the Mid-Year Examinations have been moved *forward*, from Tuesday, 12 December 2023 to Tuesday, 28 November 2023 on account of the government’s steps to counter weather constraints. The updated datesheet has been attached below for your convenience.’

I felt the need to throw up as my insides juddered continuously for a few seconds. We had almost three weeks before the main exams would even start, and in the blink of an eye, that figure virtually collapsed within itself to three days. ‘Monday would be a Prep-Leave,’ the notice consoled.

We had a batch group which included people from every nook and cranny of 9th grade. ‘Have you guys seen the notice?’ I politely asked:

‘What notice?’ said a few amongst the many.

‘Look at Teams.’

‘NO WAY!’

‘ARE THESE PEOPLE DRUNK?’

‘Welcome to *Black November*,’ I replied.

I became the bearer of ill tidings for poor Asil who had just started his own day. I had no idea what to do, and my ‘panic monkey’ had some adrenaline injected into it. We had been condemned to oblivion in the stroke of a minute, and the Mullah was unusually silent. Even he must have been grieving over the simmering tension in the school community, for it equally affected him with the haste it had affected us with.

I did not know everyone would remember this period as ‘Black November’, a term I had coined in the heat of the moment with the usual knack I had for making rhetoric. I decided to go outside and think about the past few weeks as a prerequisite for the exams; there was no time to think about recent occurrences after the bloody weekend with half the batch wounded in action.

The parent-teacher meeting was the only special arrangement that had occurred. Mum went into the Atrium with me for the first time since the Admission Interview, and a Council Member passed her the list of teachers and their designated spots in the entire school building. ‘Yes, I have Miss Bhutto for Urdu, Miss Anam for Chemistry, and Sir Rauf for Maths,’ I began. She pulled out a pen, started scribbling all the other teachers out, and off we went to the long trip into the school’s pits.

The fringes of the Hall were longer than usual, and the glistening gold of the hall descended upon us as teachers dealt with the visitors in makeshift cubicles dotted along the walls of the hall with four seats at their front for students and parents waiting, to-ing and fro-ing through the hollowness of the chamber we found ourselves in. Syed Muhammad Imaad was waiting with his mother at Miss Bhutto’s cubicle. The grey-haired woman in the cubicle was in pleasant black, vivacious as always but with a pinch of subtleness due to parents meeting her for the first time. I thought that she did not wish to let them see how eccentric she could choose to be. It might have given many conventional parents a fright.

‘Ahhhh, Ali, how are you?’ she asked after Mum and I exchanged pleasantries with her. They both began the second stage of their pleasantries, and Mum hit her with a question she had been thinking about for quite some time. ‘Ma’am, do you think he should pursue Urdu A? I mean, I was stuck in the decision between Urdu A and Urdu B.’

‘Beta (*dear*),’ she called Mum, ‘your son is an Urdu A student. I advise you to let him pursue the subject, even if he got a B in these sessionals. The result of both sessionals only make up five to ten percent of his final grade,’ she explained.

‘Yes, that’s quite decent,’ Mum remarked. ‘I had this doubt because we have family here in JT as well, you might have been teaching his cousin Zoraiz Ilyas, right?’

‘Ahhh, Zoraiz,’ she reminisced. ‘Zoraiz, Zoraiz, Zoraiz. He is the Urdu B sort, but your son is different. He will make a good Urdu A student, I can assure you of that.’

I failed to understand why she declared me an Urdu A student at the onset of O Levels, when I never even proved myself to be one of the literary types. She was not her usual expressive self as well, the candle within her had finally dimmed enough for the breeze to completely blow the dancing flame off, leaving a trail of cloudy grey smoke behind. The smoke was in her words. They did not have the usual lustre in them.

Miss Bhutto had her own whims as the weeks slid by. A weak breeze accompanied Teacher’s Day, and she waltzed into the room for her lesson. However, instead of the usual salutations and commentary before starting a funny speech or a reflective lesson on a piece of prose we had read, she solemnly stood at the front in deafening silence, turning her eyes towards us and fixing them on us for two whole minutes.

‘I have had many different experiences as a teacher,’ she began in the voice of a storyteller telling a circle of huddled campers a story in the midst of the campfire, pulling the teacher’s chair. With the grace of a nobleman, she settled down and buried herself in deep thought, gazing at the innocent ceiling above us, and the gritty floor beneath. ‘In the early 2000s, my new colleagues loathed me. They were the same old hags without the blessings of technology like those teachers in state schools,’ she uttered, looking towards the whiteboard.

‘In those days, no one extended their hand, gave their notes and resources, or even guided me to do something about the Cambridge system. I tried to infer the way they marked, and for a few years, the students in my class studied with a teacher who had literally no idea what Cambridge, or any institute

at that time, demanded from its candidates.’

‘My father made the vital decision of leaving his sardaari (*tribal leadership*) duties in Sindh, then he came to this city,’ she remembered, and the picture of an oasis in the barren southern desert flashed through my mind, while I sat there. The class fell into the pits of deafening silence, and I found myself sitting in a room of statues facing one eccentric person lamenting the past in such ardour that she had pulled our consciousness away from us.

‘Now, my brother has taken over our father’s duties. I was one of those women without the veil in a time during which such a person was out of the living memory or imagination of any “noble house” in this land, and the chastity of such a person was doubted by literally everyone. Yet, I decided to turn a deaf ear. I began teaching, and my colleagues did not cooperate. Yet, I made it through. For me, the value of monetary relief is secondary to that of my actions. Maybe on the Day of Judgement I might get to see my father smiling and saying, “Well done, Humaira. You have made me proud of my sacrifice.” Maybe the Prophet ﷺ would smile on the fact that a woman from his community had undertaken such tasks. I kept on going.’

She paused again, taking a desperate sip from the enormous grey water bottle she always carried with her. The soldier marched back to the battlefield. ‘I was offered many positions throughout my career. Once, a student was extremely rude to me and the matter was dangling over an expulsion verdict. I had been broken, but I decided to take another step. I appealed to the school for not imposing such a verdict, and I decided to leave myself. Even though the child did not understand the sanctity of what I had done, it *had to be done*. It could have left a stain on him forever.

But students, do you know what the most solemn thing for me was? When my students there got to know that I am leaving, one of them, a young girl, messaged me asking about the decision. She paused for two minutes, and I did not understand why. She finally messaged, “Today I am not losing a teacher, Ma’am.

I am losing my mother.” And—’

She never got to complete that sentence.

We had no idea that we had been paralyzed and stuffed on our bare seats, for someone had cut off all our nerves with a tiny knife while we were drawn to the front. Once the first tear broke free from her now bloodshot eyes clear as the midday sky, which we all witnessed once she rose from her desk, a stream went forth, pouring down her weary cheeks which had borne the brunt of her years. She buried her face in her palms and sobbed, as the weight of her own tears made her collapse on her chair, trying to repress the sudden outburst of realization in anguish. With great effort, she stood once again and limped towards the door. She did not look back at us with her usual smile. Her lesson was now *over*.

Something magical had happened. The ruins of Petra found themselves in one of the liveliest classes in the school with its rigorous theology, debates, anecdotes, and jest. The grating of the white clock above us filled the deep, cold void around thirty two pieces of stone, piercing through my eardrums, as everyone that they had finally run out of words to use. I just wished that she could calm down before her next lesson.

She needed someone to hug, to sob on, to lament with, to lean on that day. Providence decided not to give her such a person. It was the first time I had seen a teacher cry the way she cried in my life, and the last person I could have expected to do such a thing was an Urdu teacher. Our class was two minutes away from morphing into black-robed corteges, but our hearts were hard enough to move on and swim through the rest of the day.

Black November had begun, and I was thinking about these events outside. ‘*I had no idea what to say or even do,*’ I regretted. The days had been drawn closer than usual. The breeze around me had wafted from our class, albeit weakened by the sheer distance between us, of main roads, commercial centres and Kadir Tobpas’s blue dome. Yet, the sight was fresh within me. The day had turned colder than usual, so had Black November. The test had just begun.

CHAPTER VIII

Golden Brown

Examination week(s) came knocking on our doors once the initial practicals in the eerie corridors congested by contingents of students from different sections concluded. Potatoes had been cut and exposed to iodine, naphthalene had been melted, and the density of copper had been computed with equal amounts of haste like sacraments for an even grander ceremony.

Triumphant is he who withstands the dejection wrought by the trials and tribulations of life. The cruelty of life is such that it can push your closest friends and family; the dwellers of your heart, to the opposing end. It can sprinkle sour doubt over the hearts of those you trust. It makes the others renege their vows of unconditional support, as they think that you have become a lost cause.

The proof of their foolishness is always in your hands. You decide to trek the thorny path alone. The thorns plunge themselves into your feet, biting off the skin, freeing gushes of blood from the captivity of your veins. You stop, and let out a cry. You decide to wipe the tears off and continue. To all those who decide to take the next step even after the tribulations brought on by the thorns below, you have my respect.

It was the first examination I dealt with in LGS JT. It was the first examination where phones were expressly admitted by the Atrium –in fact, any Atrium I have dealt with. Throughout my life, I have always romanticized these days, not for the prospect of annihilation brought upon us by those wretched examinations, but the fact that the journey home always occurred as the glowy egg yolk got up and about in a blue broth casting a yellow shadow upon everything that existed on our tiny earth.

Everything was yellow and tangerine: the trees, now featuring a tint of yellow, the grounds, parks and balconies with summerly blankets floating on them, and rich pot marigolds waving at me outside, lined up in dozens on either side of the house and in the lawn marking the promised advent of better times, bottling up the fizziness of hope in the midst of the bitter cold.

The huge gold ball always decided to smile at my kitchen window as it spied on a pile of oranges. Oranges have always been a confusing subject for me. Their progeny had all these divergences which made keeping tabs on them a mind-boggling task. ‘Kinnows, maltas, fruiterers, musammis,’ the list went on. The only difference I could comprehend between them was the origin of the stock, and my mind knew only two sorts of them. We had the classic oranges of the three ancient families that you got from supermarkets or traditional stalls, and then there were the ones from this almost hidden place which had draped a veil on itself, just above the clutches of central Punjab near Bhalwal on the route to the capital, Islamabad.

There were times, I must tell you, when the rugged track towards Islamabad from the edges of such cities in central Punjab pushed you through the middle of deserted settlements: rickety buildings reeking with half-forgotten stories, desolate fields with the wildest grass some two feet tall, barren havelis (*mansions*) with ancient roofs an inch from absolute decimation, rotten wooden pillars, and no men in sight. You realize that the cunning road enticed you to step into a barren necropolis, albeit much greener and larger. You try to look for a way out, but weak network signals push you back into the realm of consciousness.

The second you start thinking of that, as if God’s angels spy on you for this very purpose, the track descends and you find yourself driving through a slice of paradise cake, with the most colossal orange trees towering upon you, rich balls of fruit hanging down along the path, and veins stemming from the main road into these lush green fields, with locals tending to their precious, beloved oranges the way we used to tend to Jackie. God unlocks the door of the past just for you in those fields, and the oranges must have been a reward for those who were patient

enough to stay upon that thread of a road. Now you knew that you were on the right track, and the ancient motorway was now a half-hour drive away.

Those oranges were twice the size of the ones back home with this unique scent of their motherland and its tenderness, and the perfect pinch of bitterness before your teeth carved into the sweet part, as the juices gushed through your mouth and onto the stillness of your tongue. The graininess of the seeds which forces one to spit them out was virtually non-existent in those oranges, and the seeds were satiny! Those seeds always slid with a bit of orange into my poor throat and it had already been too late once I sensed a bit of seed sliding down with the fruit.

The 'Black November' notice altered every nook and cranny of what a school day used to be. The entry time was moved an hour and ten minutes back to the now agreeable 8.45 AM. We were allowed to leave after the first slot, provided that we had no other examination to deal with. Watches were forbidden, and the redbud tree, the stairs to the hall, the grounds, the benches, and the corners of the castle hosted miserable students trying to swallow the entirety of the books they held in their freezing, bony hands. Students trussed up in dark blue blazers swarmed Shah Jee's canteen, and the wretched men were busy catering to a hungry, sleepless, and fatigued mob praying that the bell of penultimate judgement never rang. It did. *Thirty-seven times.*

A horde of terrified students rushed to the black door punched into the main tower with the stairwell, as beanstalks tried to squeeze themselves in twos and threes into the landing of the marbled stairs. The mob curved into the door, as the staircases swelled to hold the sheer amount of men knocking each other to the side in efforts to rush towards their seats around the school. Another mob huddled around the allotments to redeem their last chance of finding themselves in the lists stapled on them for the world to see. Panic and pandemonium ensued in the corridors as the mob diffused with books in their hands, rocking back and forth while attempting to sway the chances of the examinations obliterating them.

‘Go in the classes, children!’ Doctor Nighat recommended as she swerved through the corridors in the midst of all the chaos every single day.

Haad, Ahmer Hashmi and I decided to sit together at the benches under the redbud tree after the chaos of the first half. The deep-green flag of Pakistan, and the bony-white banner of the school flew south, along with those of the six houses before they seized themselves in conjunction to wait for the wind to change its course like military processions. For the next two minutes, they continued twirling with the wind, until the cycle ended. They paused. They continued, and paused again. A few leaves from the redbud tree fell on our head while I rubbed my eyes.

A tall, slender woman in a brown scarf surfaced on the wide window outside 10C, seeming to be our invigilator for the Add Maths examination in the second shift. Asil fixed his glasses and shook hands with me outside the class, and we both barged into the classroom together. The thirty two desks were now small vessels in the sea fighting a juggernaut advancing towards them at every stroke of the clock, every oscillation, every tick-tock.

The usual pairs had been shattered in reverence of the war. I took off my coat and waited for the clock to strike eleven, and we loaded our weaponry. People prayed, buried their heads in their palms, whispered chants and rituals.

‘You may now begin the exam,’ the woman announced.

I fired the first shot as the sea convulsed by the sheer magnitude of how far the bits of shrapnel went. I fired the next one. The enemy tried to fire back, and the sea around us shook in horror. ‘Logarithms, outdated mechanics to use for offensives,’ I thought. The logarithmic questions were quite easy. I reverse-engineered the trajectory I had taken to strike the blighters. My numbers agreed with each other. I flipped the page. I did not know how to do simultaneous equations. The method hid in the trenches of my mind, unwilling to let go of its clutches just when we were desperate for it to come out. The enemy regained momentum. It aimed its missiles, it fired on my vessels. They sank, as the sea

pulled it down to conceal the honour of my fallen ships. The few vessels at my end pulled out of the sea and sheltered themselves back at the port. We lost, though I filled the entire sheet of paper.

It was the last examination in the entire list of those blighters, the last campaign in the bloody but largely successful offensive we had conducted, and in the fullness of time, the last bit of weaponry we had garnered through the offensive was now gone. Most of us did not make it though, the enemy had fortified the capital. However, our flag rose upon their trenches. Two weeks of winter holidays were waiting for us at our verandas with open arms once we journeyed back home.

‘Happy holidays!’ We greeted each other outside the classroom. Asil and I walked together to see Haad and Shehroz getting muddled by the question paper. Haad slammed his pen on the ancient brown desk in front of my eyes. He took a deep breath, closed his eyes, and shot out of his chair like a cork. Shehroz followed him outside. ‘Happy holidays!’ We wished each other in unison.

‘I might have flunked in Add Maths,’ I remember whispering to Asil. My pitch dropped as I opened my mouth to speak again. ‘I did not know how to do the third and the fifth questions.’

‘It was easy. You had to substitute them.’

‘I forgot how to do that mate.’

I called Dad to pick me up from the battlefield. ‘I’m at the usual spot, come out,’ he yawned on the phone. I shook hands with everyone while smiling at Haad and Asil’s glistening faces as I sauntered through the grey boxes of the breathing necropolis next to the gate. The school seemed to purr before falling asleep in a distant world. The mud-brown bricks started shining, the plants started waving. ‘Goodbye JT!’ I whispered.

CHAPTER IX

Appeasement

December's dark mornings morphed into the light of January afternoons. The new year had begun, so did a new era in JT: second term. The chaos of the first term had been toned down to a point where no one could even reminisce about the chaos, and I was fit and ready for any good thing that was to happen in this term.

The sacraments of the *Paper Review* began in haste. A member of the custodian staff, the altar boy, draped in a blue sweater with the school's initials dropped a massive collection of office-brown folders on Miss Bhutto's desk, before galloping out with another pile of files destined for the other classes. We were called to her desk. 'Sign this,' she asked, passing a list with a pen, and the corresponding file.

I thought of an Islamic eschatological tradition, where on the gathering for God's final judgement, the sinners would be given their record of deeds for everlasting judgement on their left hand, while the successful and patient would get theirs on their right hand. 'Muhammad Ali Manan,' Miss Bhutto solemnly announced, snapping me out of the realm of traditions. I strolled to her desk, and extended my right hand for the file while signing for the first time in my life with the left hand. I had the record in my hand now. The results were here. 'Should I wait for a few minutes?' I thought as shivers ran down my spine.

I decided to open up my Urdu examinations first. A solid 43 and a 42 met my eyes. My mind raced back to the Urdu P1, where I decided to gamble with my grade by choosing a Tafseel (*descriptive*) piece of writing as my response to the

creative writing section. I fondly dreamed of my visit to the NHM a few months ago, and somehow, I got a 22 out of the 25 allocated for it.

‘Are you sure you gave me the right marks, Ma’am?’ I innocently asked.

‘Yes, my dear. What happened?’

‘I mean, I wasn’t expecting these marks and I am quite surprised myself.’

‘Don’t worry, I will read your mazmoon (essay) *twice* before marking it next time.’

A 34 out of 40 in Add Maths, absolute chaos in Physics, stability in Maths, and decent English grades later, break ensued upon the poor masses struggling for marks in a period when the commodity, a desire for every single student in JT, were a part of wartime rationing. *Wartime?*

‘To hell with you and your excuses at this point!’ Haad bursted at the sharp-witted, rangy man in his glistening blue coat as he decided to take off his perfectly immaculate spectacles. ‘No, you are the literal idiot here, my guy, you are mistaken beyond measure! I have had genuine reason,’ the other remarked near the sacred redbud tree where I usually laid camp for the day’s heat.

Both the Mullah and I pranced to the platforms nearby to pull the magnets of war apart. Ayaan Nasser huddled with the Mullah, whilst I pulled Haad back as Asil came sprinting from the other side. The Science Project’s inactivity had blown out the fuses of both sides. Our mycelium project was in shambles, for Ayaan Nasser tried to inch away from what he thought was an apocalypse he was pushed into, where an ordinary exchange went as follows:

Haad: ‘Yeah Nasser can you ummm, bake that in your baking oven?’

Nasser: ‘I don’t have a baking oven mate.’

Haad: ‘Okay, then can you come over to the next meeting we have?’

Nasser: ‘Hmmm.’

A black-hooded apparition made a pilgrimage to the redbud tree as the chaos in break transposed into the placidity of Sports Lesson halfway through the rising

sun. ‘Did you know that in JTI, Ayaan Nasser thought of himself as someone better than holy figures, like God forbid, the Prophet ﷺ?’

‘The *what?*’ I shrieked, while straightening myself up and leaning towards him. ‘What do you mean? I mean, you were in JTI so yeah,’ I tried to sit ramrod straight from the way I was almost lying down on those blue-green benches. I did not think of Ayaan Nasser as the sort of person to say things which could offend others.

‘Yeah, in JTI, he had an entire argument – a nasty one, mind you – with someone where he strutted around with his grades and proclaimed that quite openly. The child had the guts to say it out loud – that he was in fact misguided – and that heretic went to the Coordinator who was biased against that child. He decided to leave JTI even after getting things settled down once his parents, influential in the school’s administrative process, decided to step in,’ said he.

The boy paused for two long seconds, his breath getting heavier as he wheezed for a bit. ‘He’s a *Qadiyani*.’

‘He’s a *what?*’ I asked, as my throat dried up at the ‘what’, bemused.

‘*Qadiyani*. It’s a term for people like him.’

‘I’ve heard this term before but I didn’t know what to use it for,’ I confessed.

I just found a new narrative for the war. In retrospect, one laughs at the fact that I did not know what the term exactly meant. For me, it was just a buzzword for people having unconventional beliefs.

‘Our slogan is quite simple, gentlemen,’ I told Haad and Asil the next day as the bell for the next lesson pierced through our break at the door of the main tower inside. ‘No Mullahs, no Qadiyanis, and no people shorter than five foot seven!’

Ayaan Nasser was standing next to us. My tongue had betrayed my soul, for it spat the slogan out at a point where even the spirit of time conspired against

Ali Manan. Haadi was a step behind me. Zaid Raufi, the ‘shorter than five foot seven’ guy was on the stairwell. I faced back and decided to explain the narrative to the two behind me, letting them slide under the cover of my drunkenness. We climbed the stairs and headed towards 9G. Miss Bhutto was standing with Zaid, Haadi, and Nasser. Their mass was just outside the classroom, and they did not notice me rush into class. ‘They’re talking about you,’ my mind clicked. ‘Screw them,’ said I, in a revolting fashion.

‘Good morning class,’ Miss Bhutto smiled as she sauntered in her usual fashion for her lessons. ‘Good morning Ma’am,’ our class chirped in return. ‘Attendance it is,’ she declared.

Tension waltzed into my nostrils the second she placed her foot at the landing of our class. It hovered from the door, through the stream of students towards the front, and at my desk for a few seconds before splashing itself all over my head. My shoulders stiffened, as my jaw locked. ‘Nothing has happened,’ I sheepishly tried to console myself, ignoring the frontline now dangling outside the capital.

‘Adil Riaz Warraich, Ahmed Ayaan Nawaz, Ayaan Nasser Malik,’ she yawned while stopping between every single name. ‘Muhammad Ali Manan.’

‘Muhammad Ali Manan, I am disappointed in *you*,’ she shot out after my usual ‘Present Ma’am.’ She paused, trying to put her string of words together for the final blow on the castle walls. She whispered a prayer, focused on the mud-brown door, and pressed the trigger. As her hand pulled the trigger, an almighty cannonball knocked into the delivery chamber, leaving a few decisive seconds to the impact. ‘BOOM,’ it went, impaling the battlefield’s earthy air, crashing through the door, and smashing through the ancient, umber entrance of my mind.

The class played dead in front of the raging figure at the podium: Asil, Haad, Shehroz, Haadi, Ayaan Nasser, Zaid, Adil, Rahim Usmani, Ayaan Nawaz, and Ali Tariq Niazi gulped. Thirty students witnessed the fiery spears she threw at

one person, with eyes the size of saucers. ‘You pretend to not know about the vile things that you’re involved in,’ she shouted from the edge of the class. ‘The gravity of what *you* have been preaching, the divisions *you* have created, the enmity *you* have brought on to this class, what are you thinking?’ the woman shrieked. My lawyer, the bell, decided to screw the court apart.

My eyes grew hot and sore, struggling to push the sea of brine knocking its walls down as I stepped into the redbud tree. Everything had fallen into a state of mourning. The tree, the sun, Syed Muhammad Imaad, Haad and Asil, Shehroz, all of the things I knew and cared about decided to shun the fallen man. ‘You are the one who is going to get me into this mess,’ I remembered Shehroz’s words.

The way Miss Bhutto once shouted ‘OUT!’ due to a misunderstanding where she thought that I was talking in her class sent shivers down my spine. ‘I don’t know what I have done,’ I stuttered through the river tumbling down my eyes, while hiccuping thrice in the sentence. My cheerful voice cracked up, and the usurpers had won. No one dared to come to the redbud tree, even for the simplest consolation.

My shaky hands held on to the rim of the blue bench as I lurched forward. I had to pull myself together. I needed to pull myself together. It was the first time I had broken into tears on a school day. I struggled to keep my balance as I trekked to the bathrooms myself, as my chest rose in short, uneven pulls. The teacher I had always adored *loathed* me.

Thirty pairs of eyes stared at me when I struggled to reach for my seat in the next lesson. Beams of rage pierced through my skull, and the reactor module in it was about to explode. ‘Can I be excused Sir?’ I struggled to ask Sir Rauf. ‘Yes, you can go,’ he yawned.

‘Miss Bhutto had two sides, and one of them was particularly reserved for me,’ I first thought after looking out to the grounds. The other side, the literal hellish nightmare of an otherwise doting person, had just manifested itself. The plaque of

our class bore witness to that, so did the thirty-two students living within the bounds of that plaque.

It was all over. The war, the narratives, we had fought nothing but a war of blame. In fact, I had fought a war for nothing. The others went scot-free, without even a single bruise from the way either side fought. I harboured the hostility we had for the Mullah and Nasser in the form of battleships, missiles, and soldiers at the ports. At the end of everything, Germany got the blame. Serbia did not. The Serb had no reason to bring enmity between Germany and its foes, yet he did. He took advantage of our mutual distrust and exploited it for his own ends.

‘You should not say things like that to his face,’ Shayan Amjad advised on a silent night with an inky-black sky, dead with no star in sight. ‘Cursing someone is not a good thing, and that would just make things even more painful,’ he sighed.

‘I know, but you do not know what he did, and those things were ugly,’ I spat, two years later. The wounds lived on, and an occasional backlash was enough to help me let the moment pass. The Serb did what he could. He was the best manipulator I had ever known. He was the one I hold blameworthy for the disintegration of our class. At one point, the Mullah decided to add Miss Bhutto to our class group due to issues in communication, and that was the day Shehroz fell silent. He never spoke to me after that, even though the war was his.

‘I even supported you back then when Miss Bhutto started lashing out at the parking area,’ the pygmy would say a year later, defecating on the purity of what I had known as ‘support’. I decided to try avoiding him as much as I could, but it was all in vain.

The bell rang once again. ‘I just wish I could restart everything,’ I lamented, before crying once again.

CHAPTER X

Dunkirk

Vengeance had to wait. A tense but silent week later, on the way home, Mum looked back at me with a stern face, the one she usually had when something important was lying on the agenda or when she smelled a rat in what I had done. I tried recounting all my sins.

‘Ali,’ she began. ‘Your school called me an hour ago and they were saying that they want to do something to change English as a subject.’

‘Why though?’ I interjected. My hands shook as I thought of the events last week. I forced the thought down my throat as I leaned on the car seat. ‘They were talking about a new qualification they were introducing in English, do they normally have O-Level English?’ she probed while swerving to the Pine Avenue road.

‘Yes.’

‘They’re planning to put you in a class with IGCSE English. Check if someone else is in the same situation once we are at home.’

As much as I hated Ayaan Nasser Malik at that point, his name was the first that came spinning to my senses once I picked my phone up. ‘Ayaan, did you get that call from school?’ I hesitated before asking. My insides revolted against doing that, but I did not give a tinker’s toot.

‘Yes, and I was about to ask you about it as well,’ the reply read. ‘What are you planning to do?’ I looked out the window as the sun hid behind the clouds. ‘Asil sent a message,’ my phone buzzed.

‘Yooooo Ali, I just received this call from school and they want to put me in a “First Language English” section. Did you get such a call?’

‘Yes, and so did Ayaan Nasser,’ I smiled.

This was the only escape hatch I had available after narrowly missing absolute decimation by our old class teacher and the Mullah’s army. I had to give the school a permission document by tomorrow for the change to occur, and it could have changed my section. ‘Maybe,’ I thought, ‘Ayaan Nasser isn’t doing that. It will just be Asil and me.’ The mere thought of freedom sold all of my potential reservations about the plan. I was desperate, we needed Operation Dynamo.

‘Okay, but check with your English teacher before handing this over tomorrow Ali,’ Mum instructed before signing the ‘*Instrument of Consent*’ I had dictated in the evening which read: ‘I, the mother of Muhammad Ali Manan from Class 9G, hereby give my express permission for the allotment of IGCSE First Language English, and any change of sections which may accompany this decision.’

She had given her blessing to the Operation without knowing the tiniest particulars about it. She had no idea of the men surrounded by enemy troops which were closing in on them, pushing them into the frosty, hungry sea ready to devour them while pulling them into the depths of the earth. The men had cried for help, and help was what they were now getting in the form of a pen swivelling on the signature line. The boats left Dover for Dunkirk in batches the second she placed her pen on that line.

Jackie barked, and the walk outside reminded me of the stillness during my council interview. January’s middle act was the prescribed era in LGS JT for the Council Transition process. Interviews had become the order of the day at the Atrium, and its entrance was now guarded by the eyes of spectators around the school. A custodian’s subtle ‘This child has been called by the Admin Office’ drew unnecessary, perhaps too much attention. Such a custodian had come to us a day

before the ultimate battle in 9G's intestines. 'Muhammad Ali Manan, come to the Admin Office,' the bearded custodian announced. A few pairs of eyes escorted me to the door, with which I asked the custodian, 'Have I done something wrong?'

'No!' he playfully grinned.

The Atrium swung its doors open for its new visitor as its chambers widened to house us in, and the custodian extended his arm towards a room bearing a 'Waiting Room' plaque on the gritty wall, a tiny L-shaped establishment with warmth all around, a peach coloured wall, a bookshelf, a framed Indian motif from 2008, a neat desk, a monitor mounted on the wall next to it with footage from cameras around the Atrium, and a small rattan sofa with two small red chairs and a table at the center.

What was more peculiar was the fact that three other people were also on that rattan sofa: a tall, brawny lad with straight, greasy hair and acne scars all over his face, a shorter, plump bloke with the same sort of acne and sunburnt skin talking excitedly to the flabbiest chicken sitting in the group in silly rectangular glasses and brown hair, who stared at me when I stepped towards the chair next to him.

'I think you all are here for your Council Interviews, right?' I asked.

'Oh yes,' the sinewy one smiled. 'Also, Aayan, I think you will have the legacy factor in your interview because your brother also went through the process!' he coughed to the plump person, who introduced himself to me as Aayan Kamran. 'Raza,' Aayan said, 'that was long ago, let's see what happens.'

'What will happen to me? What will I say?' the chicken among them exclaimed. 'I don't want to go first!' he loudly thumped. 'Rohan, chill,' Raza smiled. 'I have no idea what I should choose for the Council other than debates and stuff.'

'Muhammad Ali Manan, *Doctor Nighat* awaits you in her office.'

Their eyes shot towards me. In utter disbelief, they tried to form a word or two. ‘Good luck,’ Raza gulped, scanning the bare, brown door behind me. ‘I don’t know how it will be, thanks though,’ I whispered.

The sofas for the larger waiting area next to Miss Faiqa’s office laid bare for visitors as I turned left at the edge of the Atrium with its great oak double-door. The first time I stepped into the school for the admission interview flashed before my eyes. Back then, I opened the door of her office as an eighth grader, a foreigner who was going to get naturalized. Today, I was entering as a dignitary who had been nominated for public office in her country just four months after moving.

Doc’s office was always puffy. The warmth in her office troubled me whenever I stepped into those bounds. The warmth of pink walls and the desk heater could have choked any visitor. I took a deep breath, and the preliminaries began. ‘How has JT been to you?’ she began.

I paused for a second, thinking about the question. I did not want to bring the horrors of 9G into the debate. ‘It has been quite decent for me, I must say. Everything happens to be fine.’ She smiled, reaching for my file. ‘You have been a part of the Robotics Society, I see. What would you like to apply for in the Council?’

She signalled that I could take multiple options, staring at me through her spectacles. ‘Well, both roles in the Council would require the utmost dedication, and the Prefectship would require keeping tabs on everyone in class,’ I smiled. In retrospect, I should have said the words ‘Robotics Representative’ before the word ‘Prefect’. Her pen shook as she scribbled these facts on a plain white sheet sealing our fate. The final part concluded, and out I was.

‘Twenty-five minutes,’ I told myself as the Atrium struck eleven. Not a soul breathed in the corridors within the Atrium’s reach. The doors of 9G pushed themselves open, and a swarm of excited classmates pushed through to get a glimpse of a Council candidate. ‘Did you have an interview? How did it go? What

did they ask? Who took the interview? What did you choose?' The endless questions baffled me to the core. They were too personal, yet I gave hints.

'Well it was the establishment that took it,' I smiled, straightening my tie. 'Doctor Nighat took my interview as well!' the Mullah chimed. It turned out that Miss Lubna took some interviews, while Doctor Nighat was dealing with specific candidates. Haad, Shehroz, and Ayaan Nasser were sent to the Coordinator's — a stone's throw away from our classroom. The others had to glide towards the Atrium in the pits of the earth. 'So should I infer that I had a lot of recommendations?' I wondered.

Asil and I walked to the grounds. He had applied for the Astronomy Society, and I wished him the best of luck for that. Hashim had his interview done, and a custodian came to us. 'The Coordinator wishes to speak to you both,' he wheezed.

Our consent for switching to First Language English had been ratified. 'We would not be here next Friday,' Asil confessed to Sir Hamid on Friday afternoon. Ayaan Nasser smiled from the back. Haadi was perplexed, trying to decipher the reason why. 'We decided to choose a new subject this year,' I announced, to which Sir Hamid bade us farewell. None of us knew when the ascent was to take place, including Miss Bhutto. I did not mention the fact in her classes.

None of us knew when the troubles of 9G were to end. Good Friday was nowhere to be seen. An orderly evacuation was the only solution we had for now. It did not come for weeks, a disappointment for someone who just had a row with the regime itself. Time dilates in moments like these, for objects moving faster in space slow down in terms of time. The troubles were rushing towards oblivion. Precisely when were the troubles meant to collapse? I knew not.

A whole term had passed with the troubles. Moves here, talks there, comments everywhere. The second act is yet to begin in earnest. I still had another weekend to live through. A council announcement receded into the horizon, the breezes and blossoms of February, lifting us away with it.

CHAPTER XI

St. Helena

Everlasting happiness. Stability. Victory?

Blotches of grey and brown shuddered along the car — racing on the main road — descending into nothingness as other cars swarmed with us into the boulevard, a stretch of dust and gravel etched towards the red-brick castle. The ninth hour was peeking at us from the crystalline realm of ‘near future’. 8.41 AM. The car rams into the spindly lane outside the Atrium. ‘*Have a good day,*’ Mum beamed.

Fog tumbled, carving the greens of the football ground. A yellow beam zapped, razing the mass of browns and greys concealing the marks on the earth. I looked up. The marvellous sun was nowhere in sight. My legs grew weak after every step, the wretched porcelain stairs, scarred and wide, seemed to continue forever. My stomach dropped, forcing me to make a pit stop for a few deep breaths. I continued. 9G’s doors emerged — brown, bolted, barren.

‘You ought to check the list outside,’ Khudadad Chattha advised after a glance at my pale face. The dreaded list pierced through me once again, I felt like throwing up there and then. Asil trotted in. ‘Did you check your attendance card today?’ he asked. Rummaging through the bag, I felt a ragged corner of unforgiving plastic, ripe for scanning. We broke into a run, collapsing by the computer’s side. I slammed the card on the miniscule scanner taped to the Coordinator’s window. The computer froze.

‘Muhammad Ali Manan, 9D. Present at 8.45 AM,’ the screen read. ‘They changed the sections TODAY!’ Asil exclaimed with disbelief in his eyes which poured down his glasses. A lanky student naively placed his card on the

blinking scanner. 'Ibrahim Ataullah, 9G, Present at 8.52 AM.' Ibrahim's eyes swelled, until they became the size of saucers. He was supposedly a student from 9D. They had shuffled dozens of students. 'I think we should go now,' I coughed, returning to my senses.

My feet trudged to the left corridor rather than the usual right. 9F, 9E, and finally, 9D emerged from the edge of the granite floor. A rusty orange doorframe stood at the mouth of the next corridor, confining everyone and marking 9D as the frontier between the known and the unknown. I pushed the door.

Nothing. The class was wider than 9G, almost certainly twice as large. An enormous window, hammered into the rear wall, lined up with the whiteboard resting at the corner of the front wall. An enormous array of windows guarded the other end of the classroom, concealing it from the rusty orange gate. Perhaps the most peculiar arrangement was that of the tables themselves; rows of twos with curved chairs that were heavenly, compared to those from the old realm. Rayyan Fahmeed smiled at me from the front. I had actually forgotten about his presence in the new world.

Ayaan Nasser had already picked a spot for himself near the whiteboard, chuckling with a scrawny peer of ours with darting brown eyes, a fuzzy moustache and a jawline that must have been chiseled by the Greeks. Sitting right beside them was a freckled lad with the most protruding ears, ears that jutted out of his head like cliffs, blade-rimmed as if a goat had chewed upon them. The big-eared boy was whispering in the ear of another eccentric figure with a pumpkin-shaped head and long, silky hair concealing every bit of the slab. Every living soul in that radius had a wispy stand of hair above their lips. I coughed, before sitting down.

The door creaked open, and in came a paler Hashim Chaudhry. He stopped in his tracks, breathing in the uncertainty of the Frankenstein he found himself in, rubbing his yellowed hands all over his forehead before letting out a sigh, a wail of despair that sailed through the new students.

‘You’re here?’ he smiled, stepping to my desk. I stood up, chuckling while looking out the window. ‘Yes,’ I uttered, realising that I ran out of words for a witty remark. ‘I think you should look at the timetable for the lessons here.’

We rushed to the rear end of the class, where the custodians usually attached notices and disciplinary announcements. The jet-black softboards, bruised with holes from repetitive pinning, fading from the edges, played host to the schedule. My eyes rested on the initials ‘HB’ under the Urdu schedules. I felt queasy. ‘The woman is going to screw me up now,’ I thought.

And screw me up she *did*.

Our class teacher was absent. Miss Bhutto sauntered in, plonking her books and registers on the rostrum. She groaned. ‘Good morning everyone,’ she beamed, scanning the class. ‘I see many new people here,’ she mouthed, observing the immigrants before reaching for her spectacles. Attendance began. The class fell silent.

With every name and consequent hiccup, she swivelled her pen. The swivelling stopped halfway through the purple register. ‘Muhammad Ali Manan,’ she repulsively coughed, leaning on the orange rostrum, swinging it by leaning at different angles. ‘You do know that you are a very negative person,’ she lamented, placing her pen down. Beams of hatred shot from her eyes into mine, and a mysterious force made my hands twitch under the desk’s drawer. My arms followed suit, forcing me to bury them under the desk to conceal everything. It was too much now.

The big-eared student’s face bore a smile. People around me stared in the depths of my eyes, which were almost burning with rage. I felt the soreness around them, and I instinctively covered them with my sweaty palm. No one needed to witness a breakdown on the first day of class.

‘People idolise evil men who lived in the realm of history,’ she sighed. ‘It is your choice if you want to become like them. I cannot stop anyone from this

stupidity, and it is the worst thing you could do.’ The bell raced into the class, crashing its chariot into the rostrum. ‘I will see you all in the afternoon,’ she declared.

Add Maths. A stumpy, old man with jagged black and grey hair stomped in. ‘Oh ho ho!’ he exclaimed. ‘New students!’ he smiled, before jumping towards the teacher’s chair. The first thing I noticed once he faced us was his disproportionate pair of horn-rimmed glasses which ridiculously enlarged his eyes. A gruff moustache, flabs of skin on the neck, hair on the ears. ‘Where is Dayem? Is he still here or was he shipped to another class?’

‘Unfortunately Sir Nadeem, he didn’t make it here,’ the big-eared one smiled, showing his gritty teeth. ‘Well Hassan, he was a nice guy. For those who have no idea who I am talking about, ask the old students from this class. Dayem was a very funny child, you know. He actually got his finger stuck in one of these desks here!’

He reached for Hassan’s desk and pointed at a small hole stamped on the drawer. His face lit up, reminiscing the faint outline of a mythical finger struggling to squirm out. ‘I told the boy, “Pull, you nitwit! Twist your damn finger while you are at it!” At the end, we had to call the custodian and he had to rub oil on his finger.’ The old man smirked, sealing his lips shut before squinting through his spectacles.

‘Today we are going to do Logarithms and oh boy, that is one easy chapter,’ he bursted before scurrying off to the whiteboard, tilting the black marker in the process. ‘I need a textbook.’

‘I need a textbook,’ he panted once again.

‘We would be doing logarithms today, open Exercise 3.2,’ he paused, allowing me to gawk at Asil, who gawked back at me. Sir Hamid was surfing through the depths of Chapter 2. Question 1. ‘So this is how you do it,’ he exclaimed, printing

the solution on the board. Sir Nadeem repeated the method for Question 2. ‘This is too easy,’ he sighed. ‘Who wants to do the last question on the board?’

‘Who wants to do the last question on the board?’

Sir Nadeem’s voice rang in my ears. We did not know what logarithms meant. We did not know how to relate them to the rudimentary basics from indices. We did not even *digest* the basics of logarithms, and the madman threw us to the most complex problems the Singaporeans had compiled. ‘I will,’ said another scrawny beanstalk with curly hair and braces.

‘Chaudhry, come on son.’

And somehow, with sheer magic, ‘Chaudhry’ scribbled all the gibberish in a matter of seconds, snorting as if he was asked to clean up after himself. I remember staring at him with my mouth wide open. The bell rang again. ‘I will see you after the break for Maths,’ Sir Nadeem chuckled.

‘Asil!’ I cried out, rushing towards the only person I knew in the place.

‘We are screwed beyond measure,’ he began.

‘My guy, the man is going to ruin Add Maths for us, and the worst thing is that Miss Bhutto is not going to absolve me now.’

Hassan and the eccentric figures around him laid their eyes on us from the farthest end of the football ground. Break vanished from the depths of existence. The bell marched once again. ‘Does anyone here know how many centimetres there are in an inch?’ he inquired.

‘Two-point-five-four!’ I spat, raising my hand.

The man looked at me in the most incriminating way he could, scraping every inch of my face — forehead, eyebrows, eyelashes, eyelids, irises, nose, lips, chin, earlobes — scouting in different directions, shooting the most piercing red beams. ‘What on *earth* do you measure, boy?’ he chuckled. The class leaned back to take a good look at me. Why did they find it to be odd? I knew not.

At least Sir Nadeem was better in normal Mathematics. ‘You know, I teach A-Levels here as well. They’ve always given me the “D” sections in O-Levels, 9D, 10D, and 11D,’ he paused, before breaking into a run once more. ‘Abdullah Shahid Sial — the one in Harvard now — was in these classes just like you all are now. He was in fact in 9D!’ he smiled, looking back at the world of centuries past.

‘I never skip days in school, that is a record of mine for the past twenty years!’ Sir Nadeem exclaimed. He was now on his feet. The board marker rolled over the rostrum, begging for someone to put the cap on. ‘The only time I skipped a day was when I went to Islamabad for my son’s admission at Brown.’

My mind pounded. ‘If my messiah, the bell, did not go off within two minutes, my skull would crack with the throbbing,’ I thought. Providence decided to spare us. The bell rang.

The sun rode away, sinking to the edge of the class, peeking at us one last time through the array of windows pushing its rays back, toning down the air around us. The door glided. Three new figures came in: a gigantic, solid wall of muscle and bulk, a well-built athlete with darting eyes walking with the grace of a nobleman, and a scraggy fledgling with a bushy crop of oily hair, spectacles and strands of thin hair all over the face, who decided to stoop into the perimeter, stretching his bony legs with every uneven stride. The scraggy one sat in my row, skipping a seat.

‘H-h-hi,’ he struggled to say, trying to form a broken smile.

He introduced himself as Naiel. I shook his hand, making sure I did not shake it so hard as to pluck it off his flimsy arm. I looked around, noticing another moustached individual with jet-black hair and almond eyes. ‘Hello,’ I began, to which he responded with the usual preliminaries.

‘I’m Rayyan.’

‘Which one? Aren’t there three Rayyans in this class?’ I interjected.

‘I’m Rayyan Naveed,’ he smiled.

‘Oh, nice to meet you, I’m Ali.’

We smiled at each other. ‘Good morning Sir Imran!’ a chorus erupted from the rear. I stood up in a jiffy for the one Rayyan Fahmeed talked about months ago. A sharp tinge of green zapped through my poor eyes as the man solemnly ambled to the front.

He ceremoniously turned a hundred and eighty degrees, breathing in the naivety of immigrants around him with his hawk nose. His oily hair tried to conceal his bald head in vain, resting in slight curls above his ears, which surrounded his pudgy face perching on a corpulent frame. He curled his lips into the slightest smile before coughing into the lesson, his ashy jowls sinking in the process. ‘Zayan, plug in my laptop for me, would you?’ he shook his head, gazing at the computer’s ports.

The pumpkin-headed bloke got up. As he fiddled with the ports, Sir Imran fetched a board marker. He rubbed the marker along the whiteboard, leaving perfectly even, long lines before curving them in the most eccentric fashion to form dainty letters.

‘The school has chosen all of you as the first class that would experience First Language English,’ he grunted. ‘The other people used to have double-one-two-three, which is O-Level English. The examiner...’ Sir Imran had a very distinctive way of speaking, an idiolect, a unique way of pronouncing words. His presentation featured a dazzling, overwhelming stream of yellow and blue, enough to blind a person. Excerpts of orange-white marking schemes and instructions from Cambridge examiners, blood-red headings. He was geared to the brim.

‘From the next lesson, we will begin working on the first drafts of your narrative writing components,’ he snapped, rushing to the door in a jiffy. The day was finally over. I smiled at Rayyan once again, wishing him goodbye. In the blink of an eye, home emerged. I strapped on my headset, burying myself in an immersive game.

I might have lived to see another day.